Gracefully Broken

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38035633.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Swift Wind (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra), The Squad (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Enemies to Lovers, Mutual Pining, Hurt/Comfort, Amnesia, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Despara (He-Man), Warning: Horde Prime (She-Ra), Major Character Death: Hordak/ Horde Prime and Shadow Weaver, (no one else dies), Catra and Adora are idiots in love, Both of them nearly die, They both need therapy and hugs, Happy Ending, Catradora Forever

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Something Has To Break

Stats:
Published: 2022-03-29 Completed: 2022-05-07 Words: 29,079 Chapters: 8/8

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by commander_lioness

Summary

"Catra? Is that you?" Catra immediately looked up, leaned over Adora and said:

"Yes. It's me. I'm here." Adora had never been more comforted in her life. She now remembered enough about what had happened to her to know that she was dying – that something on Beast Island had killed her. And yet, in her final moments, Catra, the girl who she could never hate, and who she lived to see on the battlefield, was by her side.

OR

I know Catra saving Adora from a Horde-related lethal injury has been done so many times already, but I love the idea and want to contribute my version. That being said, there will be some smut (just kissing), a lot of mutual pining and, as always, a happy ending :)

Adora Dies...?

Chapter Notes

If the fic summary, chapter name and cover art didn't make it clear enough, I will - Get ready for a whole lot of angst! ;) Thanks for reading - I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Amazing artwork commissioned from @profound-drawings on Tumblr! :)

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Catra sat on the floor of the Forge with no intention of ever getting up again. Everything hurt but she did not care. She had lost. Double Trouble had totally exposed her and they had assured her defeat at the hands of the Rebellion. Catra looked down at the ground sadly. She hated to admit it, but Double Trouble was right. Her heart had never been in this fight. She had never wanted to be the villain. All she wanted – all she had ever wanted – was Adora.

Catra sighed and looked over at where Hordak lay unconscious and trapped under debris. She gave a tiny smirk. At least she beat him. If anyone deserved a taste of his own medicine, it was him. As she began to reminisce about the numerous times Hordak had hurt her, Glimmer suddenly materialized in front of her. Catra did not move and simply stared at her before looking down again. It was happening. The Rebellion had won, just as Double Trouble had said, and now they had come for her. At least it was the queen bringing her in. She could not cope with Adora right now, and she had little to no respect for any of the other princesses.

A long moment passed where no one spoke nor moved. The silence grew increasingly unnerving, and Catra finally looked back up at Glimmer. She was surprised to see her crying silently – her face bright red with tears rolling down her cheeks. She was staring hard at Catra, clenching her magic staff in her hand as she did so. It looked like she wanted to kill her, but was willing herself not to. Catra, believing there was nothing she deserved more, said:

"What are you waiting for? Do it." Glimmer gasped in response, prompting Catra to continue:

"Looks like we're both alone, Sparkles." Glimmer frowned and wiped the tears from her eyes before exclaiming:

"What? No – I'm not going to kill you!" Catra gave a small chuckle:

“Why not? I thought you wanted to win.” Glimmer groaned in frustration, but, much to Catra’s surprise, that groan turned to a sob, and Glimmer suddenly collapsed on the floor - hugging herself as she cried. Catra raised an eyebrow and hesitantly moved forward, putting a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. She sighed:

“Hey, I get it. I thought winning would be different too.” Catra was not sure where this sudden display of sympathy came from. There was definitely no love lost between them. Maybe Double Trouble’s lecture had brought out a softer side in her? Who knew? Glimmer then surprised her again by taking her hand and desperately pleading:

“No, you don’t understand! Adora is dying! She went to Beast Island to rescue Entrapta and got hit by some kind of death ray! Bow and Swift Wind somehow managed to get her back to Brightmoon before I left, but nothing we’ve done has helped! At the moment, Shadow Weaver’s magic is all that’s keeping her alive!” Catra’s eyes had grown wide in horror as Glimmer spoke, but had narrowed once again at the mention of Shadow Weaver. She scoffed:

“Oh, she’ll be fine. Shadow Weaver won’t give up on her. Adora was always her favourite.” Glimmer glared at Catra before yelling:

“Did you not hear what I said? Adora is dying!” Catra rolled her eyes and pulled her hand away:

“Yes, I heard you. Poor old Adora – it’s not like she’s almost been killed before.” Catra gave a wry chuckle before going silent once more. While she could not deny her feelings for Adora, and the very real concern she had for her wellbeing, Catra was really not sure how to convey that to Glimmer, and was doubtful she would believe her if she did. The two sat in silence for a long time before Glimmer’s tracker pad began to ring. She pulled it out and answered it. Catra recognized Bow on the screen.

“Glimmer! Have you found her yet?” Glimmer gave a tearful nod and murmured:

“Mmhmm.” Catra’s eyes went wide as Bow continued:

“Well, have you talked to her? Can you bring her back here? Adora’s getting worse and now she’s screaming for her!” Catra was then able to make out faint cries in the background. They were cries of pain, and they were cries of her name. Catra immediately reached out and grabbed the tracker pad. Glimmer did not stop her. She almost yelled at Bow:

“Okay, listen Arrow Boy! Enough tricks! What are you and Sparkles up to? If this is some sick ploy to get me to come with you without a fight, it’s not necessary! I surrender, okay? Just stop this ‘Adora dying’ nonsense!” Bow seemed surprised by Catra’s sudden appearance on his screen, but then his expression softened and he said:

“Catra, I’m sorry to tell you this, but we’re not lying. Adora really is dying and Entrapta said you’re the only one who could save her. Glimmer wants to bring you here to do that – not to arrest you.” Glimmer then growled at Catra:

“We’ll see about that. Don’t think I haven’t forgotten everything you’ve done!” Bow then interrupted her:

“Glimmer! Not the time!” Catra ignored both of them and groaned:

“Okay, hold on! Entrapta has been wrong before – how do you know she’s right this time? Also, why am I be the only one who could save her? Don’t you have enough magic and powers to fix the problem yourselves?” Bow sighed before saying:

“We’ve tried everything. Entrapta said the ray gun was something she made a while ago, and that it was wired specifically to She-Ra’s DNA. She also said that you’re the only one who could administer the antidote.” Catra gasped in realization. Her mind took her back a year ago, just after the incident in the Northern

Reach. Catra had asked Entrapta to find another way to infect She-Ra – to take control of her – like the virus had done. Only this time, the effects would be permanent and Catra would have full control over her.

After a day of working, Entrapta had made a ray gun that, when fired at Adora, would supposedly rewrite her DNA so she would lose all sense of self and be free to control. After running some more tests, however, Entrapta had confirmed it would actually go far beyond that and kill Adora before Catra could make her do anything. Upon learning this, Catra had changed her mind and, fearing someone like Hordak would get his hands on the gun, she had had the device dumped on Beast Island – never to be seen again. Only it apparently had been, and Adora was now suffering an extremely painful death. Catra pinched her nose and muttered:

"Right, of course. The ray gun." She then turned to Glimmer, who was now scowling at her with fresh hatred in her eyes. Her emotional breakdown made sense now. She had presumably been on her way to activate the weapon Double Trouble had mentioned, only then she had had to pause her plans to save her friend. Not only that, but she had had to come and seek help from the very person responsible for all the pain Adora was in, and all the pain she and thousands more had suffered over the past few months. Catra understood – she would not have been able to cope with it either. With that realization, Catra tentatively reached out to Glimmer and took her hand.

"Take me to her."

***

Adora was writhing around in her bed. Her mind was filled with visions of her old life in the Horde, and of Catra's face. Catra's beautiful face that Adora missed so much. She could vaguely make out someone calling her name. She could then hear Shadow Weaver talking to someone and saying her name. That brought back the memories of her hurting Catra – electrocuting her for the smallest mistakes. Adora screamed once again:

“Catra!”

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After Glimmer teleported Catra to the throne room of Brightmoon, Catra collapsed on the stone floor, trying to get her bearings. Her head ached and she was extremely dizzy. Not only that, but she was now very aware that she had badly hurt her leg, and that at least two of her ribs were broken during her fight with Hordak. She really was in no condition to do anything. Once she recovered, Catra slowly got to her feet, leaned her weight on her good foot, and silently followed Glimmer as she led her through the palace.

The walk took longer than expected, and Catra could not help but scowl at her surroundings. Everything was so bright and colourful – the total opposite of the Fright Zone (not that Catra liked its aesthetic, but it was what she was used to). As they approached Adora’s room, two guards appeared on either side of her. Catra would normally have fought them off, or at least made some snide remark about whether or not two guards would be enough to stop her, but she did not. Believe it or not, she was really worried about Adora.

Catra remembered what Entrapta had told her about the ray gun, and all the negative effects it would have. Adora’s body was literally degenerating - she must be in a ridiculous amount of pain. She did not deserve that – she could never deserve that. Catra had to administer the antidote. That was where she was confused, however. She could not remember what the cure was, nor where it was, yet alone how to administer it. She should have thought to ask Entrapta through the tracker pad, but she had been so obsessed with seeing Adora that she had forgotten to do so.

They finally arrived at Adora’s room, and Glimmer told the guards to wait outside. She then opened the door and walked in. Catra limped in after her. The room was dimly lit and eerily silent. The

silence was soon broken, however, with Bow rushing up to Glimmer and hugging her:

"You're back! I'm so glad you're okay!" Glimmer hugged him back without saying anything. Wow, Catra thought, she is really not acting like herself. Catra then looked over to where Adora's bed was, and saw the unmistakable outline of Shadow Weaver next to it - blocking her view of Adora. The two of them locked eyes and Catra hissed at her. That was when someone grabbed her from behind, and she felt herself wrapped in a familiar bear hug:

"Catra! You came! I knew you'd want to save Adora!" Catra screamed and pushed her way out of Scorpia's grasp before recognizing her former friend. She paused and spluttered: "S…Scorpia? What…" She was then interrupted by a familiar tuft of hair wrapping around her arm and dragging her over to the bed. Entrapta looked up at her from her crouched position at Adora's side.

"Hey Catra" Entrapta said without her usual enthusiasm. Catra's face went white. She was not ready to see her again. Entrapta continued:

"Adora was hit by the ray gun I made. My data was correct – it's killing her." Entrapta's voice sounded so sad. Using her heightened senses, Catra was able to see that she was crying. Entrapta then murmured sadly:

"I didn't want this to happen. I didn't want Adora to get hurt because of me." Catra looked around nervously and, realizing that no one was going to say anything to comfort her, she leaned down and gave Entrapta a small smile:

"She's hurt because of me, Entrapta. You did nothing wrong." Entrapta turned to look at her with a confused expression.

"But…I made the gun." Catra groaned. She had forgotten that Entrapta took everything literally. She growled (mostly at herself):

“At my request.” She then took a deep breath and was about to ask Entrapta about the cure, when Adora suddenly made her presence known. She began thrashing around in the bed screaming:

“No! No! NO! CATRA!” Catra gasped and instinctually leaned over Adora and scooped her up in her arms. The last time she had done this had been more than three years ago, right before Adora had become a Force Captain and left her. They had been about to do their final set of exams as senior cadets, and Adora had had a terrible panic attack that had sent her into a similar physical state. Catra had held her close and purred against her chest for almost an hour to calm her down. It had worked then, but it was not working now. Adora kept thrashing, even more so now she felt someone holding her. She pushed Catra off her and continued screaming:

“CATRA! CATRA!” Entrapta then spoke up:

“Remember how the whole purpose of this gun was for you to control her? This is her fighting against it. Her resistance is killing her. That’s how I knew the ray was lethal. When I made it, I did not consider her fighting against it.” Catra’s eyes went wide and she looked around the room once again. Still no one said anything. What was wrong with them? She then stared across the bed at Shadow Weaver. Shadow Weaver then spoke:

“It’s your fault this is happening, Catra. Fix it or I will not hesitate to finish what I started!” Catra then yelled:

“Finish what you started?! You mean abusing me and Adora to the point of almost killing us? Turning me into a villain while you get to be the good guy? You’re in no position to make threats! I defeated you, remember? We both did!” Glimmer then yelled:

“Enough! We don’t have time for this! Catra, please save Adora!” Adora had now stopped screaming and had collapsed back on the bed. She was motionless and her breathing was ragged. She did

not have long. Catra quickly turned back to Entrapta and put her hands on her shoulders.

“Okay, Entrapta, how do I fix this?” Entrapta looked up at her sadly and pointed at Catra’s head.

“With that.” Catra’s face went red and she all but yelled:

“With what? My brain? My mane? What are you trying to say? Use your words, Entrapta!” Entrapta then replied with a hurt tone in her voice:

“No – your mask. You can heal her with your mask.” Catra stared blankly at Entrapta before asking:

“My mask is the cure? How?” Entrapta perked up a little as she explained:

“Your mask is actually a relic of the ancient kingdom of Halfmoon – made from an extremely rare substance that doesn’t even have a name! It’s what the rune stones are made of!” Catra raised her eyebrow as Entrapta got increasingly excited:

“I was always curious about it, and Scorpia said that her dad had a few masks like it before he surrendered his kingdom to the Horde. So, while you were sleeping, I examined it and used its material to successfully counteract the chemical agent in the ray.” Catra finally exclaimed in disbelief:

“So, I’ve been wearing a ground up runestone on my head this whole time?!” Shadow Weaver then interjected:

“That’s not important now! Break it – snap it in half!” Scorpia then stepped forward and said:

“Hey, wait a minute! Adora gave her that mask! I remember – Catra told me. I don’t think Adora would want her to break it.” Glimmer then turned to Scorpia angrily:

“And what are we supposed to do instead? Go and look for the other masks your father may or may not have owned, which may or may not still be in the Fright Zone?” Catra then interrupted by yelling:

“Shut up!” She then paused before saying:

“Don’t speak to Scorpia like that.” There we go, Catra thought, I came to her defense – is that not what a good friend does? Before anyone could say anything else, one of the guards outside burst in saying the princesses had returned from the battle outside Brightmoon. Glimmer put her face in her hands and wailed:

“I can’t do this! I CAN’T DO THIS!” Bow then put his hands on her shoulders and walked her out of the room. They were promptly followed by Swift Wind and a guy with a beard and purple outfit. Both of them had been quiet the entire time. Scorpia then turned to Catra and said:

“Thanks, Wildcat.” Catra smiled as Scorpia then turned to Entrapta and said:

“Come on, let’s go and say hi! We’ll let Catra heal Adora by herself.” Entrapta raised her eyebrow and asked uncertainly:

“Are you sure? The data shows she hates Adora.” Catra rolled her eyes:

“I don’t hate her, I just…it’s complicated.” Catra then slowly pulled her mask off her face, feeling the sharp edges of it with her fingers. Feeling confident that Catra would actually follow her instructions on healing Adora, Entrapta slowly got up and walked over to Scorpia. Scorpia then grabbed Shadow Weaver by the shoulder and said:

“Come on, witch lady! Let’s give these two some privacy!” Shadow Weaver shook Scorpia’s claw off her shoulder and yelled:

“Are you mad?! I’m not leaving her alone with her! My magic’s all that’s keeping her alive!” As if on cue, Adora began to moan

Catra's name again, and Catra glared at Shadow Weaver:

"'Ever think that your magic might be the problem?" Before Shadow Weaver could protest, Scorpia literally dragged her out of the room – completely unfazed by her threats and attempts to break free. The loss of Shadow Weaver's magic saw Adora steadily decline even further, to the point that her breathing was barely audible. She did stop squirming and moaning, however, and now seemed to finally be at peace.

Catra felt herself get teary-eyed. Without much effort, she snapped her mask in half and then broke off a tiny piece of it. She then realized she could not let Adora swallow a large sharp piece of metal, so she proceeded to use her claws to round off its edges, making it considerably smaller. She had almost finished when Adora started to speak:

"Catra? Is that you?" Catra turned to look at Adora in total shock. Her voice had almost been inaudible – she was so weak and clearly in a lot of pain. Catra leaned over her and said:

"Yes. It's me. I'm here." Adora then weakly reached out her hand towards Catra, aiming for her cheek but completely missing it. Catra caught her hand and held it against her cheek for her. Adora smiled. Her eyes were shining in the dark – as beautiful as they had always been. The number of times Catra had let herself get lost in those eyes were innumerable. Adora then muttered:

"You're so beautiful. I love you." She then closed her eyes and her body finally went limp. Catra gasped before screaming:

"Adora? ADORA!" She quickly finished what she had been doing to the piece of her mask and forced Adora's mouth open - practically pushing it down her throat. She then began to apply CPR, hoping that that would somehow make a difference. She and Adora had had to practice doing this on each other multiple times in the Horde. She could not believe she was now having to do it for real. Focused on keeping Adora alive, Catra refused to let her mind

wander to what Adora had said, and what that truly meant for both of them.

***

At some point, the visions of her past had stopped, and her mind had cleared enough for her to see what was around her. Adora had searched frantically for clues as to her whereabouts – deducing she was in her room based on the giant curtains hanging over her head. She had then looked around for someone, anyone, who could help her figure out what was happening. For whatever reason, she was too weak to move and found herself unable to scream. That was when she saw her – Catra.

At first, Adora did not think she was real. Not only did Catra have her iconic mask off (she never took it off), but she was playing with it. It lay broken in her hands. Adora was confused by this, and wondered whether this was Catra's way of severing their connection forever. They definitely had one and, despite everything that had happened, it was still there. She then realized that Catra was not angry or resentful like she normally was. She was sad – almost regretful. Adora then summoned all her strength to ask:

"Catra? Is that you?" Catra had immediately looked up, leaned over her and said:

"Yes. It's me. I'm here." Adora had never been more comforted in her life. She now remembered enough about what had happened to her to know that she was dying – that something on Beast Island had killed her. And yet, in her final moments, Catra, the girl who she could never hate, and who she lived to see on the battlefield, was by her side. Adora once again summoned all her strength to raise her hand to touch Catra's cheek, but the action made her dizzy and her hand swayed. Catra caught it, however, and held Adora's hand to its intended destination.

Adora smiled. Catra's cheek was so soft. She realized she had not touched it in literal years, and she had missed it. She had really

missed Catra. She then looked up at Catra’s beautiful blue and yellow eyes, perfectly encased in her gorgeous mane which, without the mask, looked so elegant and sexy. As Adora felt her heart beating slower with each final breath, she murmured:

“You’re so beautiful. I love you.” She then passed out and could just make out Catra screaming her name.

Chapter End Notes

Well, there you have it! Don't worry - Adora will be fine, and this is not even the worst thing that'll happen to her in this fic! Why do I do this, you ask? It's a good question - one that I'm too scared to answer. Anyway, this fic will be regularly updated (like my other one), so feel free to bookmark! As always, comments and kudos are greatly appreciated! I hope you enjoy! :)

Adora Forgets Everything

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! Thank you so much for all the comments and kudos! They mean so much to me! Here is the next chapter as promised. I apologize in advance for the pain you are about to suffer.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Catra? Catra, where are you?" Adora ran through the halls of the Fright Zone, getting increasingly worried about her feline friend. It had been several hours since she had last seen her – since Shadow Weaver had dragged her away. Catra had dared to disobey her orders during a training simulation, and had instead sacrificed herself to save Adora - again. Now she was being punished - again. Adora sighed and paused her search. Shadow Weaver should have released Catra by now. She could not still be undergoing punishment. Could she?

***

"Hold on – Catra is in there right now? CATRA?!" Mermista yelled in disbelief. Glimmer pinched her nose before taking a deep breath.

"Look, I'm not happy about it either, but *someone* disobeyed my orders and went to Beast Island – and now Adora is dying and only Catra can save her." Bow frowned and said:

"That's not fair, Glimmer. We rescued Entrapta and your dad." Glimmer groaned before muttering:

"Yes, okay - sorry! I'm just really worried about Adora. She's my friend – my best friend. If she dies, I don't know what I'll do…" Glimmer then burst into tears and collapsed in Bow's arms. Mermista awkwardly looked away while everyone else averted their eyes. No one wanted to see the queen cry.

***

Catra lay in a bed in the med bay, completely unable to move. After Shadow Weaver was done electrocuting her, she had decided to test some awful paralyzing agent on her. It was supposed to wear off eventually, but she had been lying like this for almost two hours and was getting genuinely concerned that she would never be able to move again. As her eyes began to well up with yet more tears she could not wipe away, Catra heard a familiar yell:

"Catra? Are you in here?" Catra closed her eyes. It was the only part of her body she could move. She did not want to see Adora. She could not cope with those beautiful eyes filling with tears.

***

Shadow Weaver broke the tension by stepping forward and saying:

"Your majesty, you have to let me back in there! You do not know Catra like I do – she does not care about Adora! She's probably letting her die as we speak!" Scorpia then yelled:

"That's not true! Catra cares for Adora! She wants to save her!" She then turned to Bow, who was still holding a sobbing Glimmer, and asked:

"Didn't you say she agreed to come?" Bow nodded and said:

"She surrendered." Mermista then growled:

"If she surrendered, then why is she by herself in a room with our friend? Someone needs to be in there with her! She needs to be arrested for her crimes!" Entrapta then put her hand on Mermista's arm, making her jump and look down. She spoke quietly:

"Catra is not a good friend. She betrayed me and sent me to Beast Island. But all the data shows that she wants to save Adora,

and she is more likely to succeed if she is alone with her."

***

When Adora saw Catra lying on the bed nearest to the entrance of the med bay, her heart sank. Catra had bandages along her arms, legs and across part of her face. Her uniform was torn and looked like it had been set on fire. That was not what alarmed Adora the most, however. Catra was not moving – at all. Adora immediately ran over to her and saw that her eyes were closed. She screamed:

"CATRA! CATRA, WAKE UP!" Catra slowly opened her eyes and tears rolled down her cheeks. Adora resisted the urge to cry as she picked up Catra's hand and pressed it to her cheek. She forced herself to smile as she said:

"It's okay, Catra. It's just me. I'm here."

***

Micah finally stepped forward, clearing his throat as he did so. He said:

"Right, well, I must say I wish I was meeting you all under better circumstances. I'm very sorry that Adora, who risked her life to save mine, is now in danger of losing it. While there is little I can do to help her, I would like to offer to help you, baby g– I mean, Queen Glimmer." He coughed awkwardly before continuing. Everyone eyed him with varying degrees of curiosity and wariness.

"I suggest we all adjourn to the war room and discuss what needs to happen now that the Rebellion has won a decisive victory over the Horde. Not only is their army defeated, but we have their second-in-command within these walls right now as our prisoner. The sooner we strike, the greatest chance we'll have of victory." He turned to Glimmer, who had stopped crying and was wiping her eyes like a little child. He asked:

"Would that be a good idea, Glimmer?" Glimmer looked up at her dad and nodded. The two of them had not had much of a reunion

since his arrival, and her concern for Adora currently overshadowed her joy at seeing him again. Upon seeing her nod, Micah wordlessly turned and headed to the war room. Everyone silently followed him. Soon it was just Bow and Glimmer standing in the corridor outside Adora's room.

***

Catra stared at Adora longingly. She knew that no one else even remotely cared that she had been fried within an inch of her life, only to then be used as a test subject for one of Shadow Weaver's sick experiments. Only Adora cared. For some reason, Adora not only saw her as a person, but as a friend. That was why Catra would always jump in the way of the lasers in the training simulations. It was why she would always cover for Adora whenever she did something wrong. It was also why she would always stand by her and support her, even when Catra herself was consistently let down and abandoned by everyone around her.

Another hour passed with little to no movement on Adora's part. Then Catra suddenly regained feeling in her face and breathed out:

"Hey Adora."

***

It had been several minutes since everyone had left for the war room. Glimmer had almost fallen asleep in Bow's arms when he finally broke the silence:

"Glimmer, we need to talk." Glimmer sighed and, without moving, asked:

"About what? How you didn't listen to me? How you don't trust me? How this is all your fault?" Bow took a deep breath before replying:

"No, Glimmer. It's not my fault. Entrapta needed us. Not only that, but she taught us more about the Heart of Etheria than we

could've ever hoped to learn on our own. We now know that it must never be activated!" Glimmer groaned and stepped away from Bow.

"I also learned about the Heart of Etheria from Light Hope. It's not nearly as bad as Entrapta made it seem! All we have to do is get Scorpia to the Black Garnet chamber so she can re-connect with her runestone. Then the planet will be balanced and the magic will be released!" Bow finally raised his voice:

"Yes – through She-Ra! She-Ra is the weapon, and she's currently lying unconscious in her room needing her worst enemy to save her!" Glimmer's eyes went wide as she yelled:

"That's not my fault, Bow! I told you not to go to Beast Island! I know it sounds bad, but Entrapta could've waited! My dad's been waiting for years! If you two had not gone like I asked you to, Adora would not be dying right now!" As if on cue, Catra's voice was then heard screaming:

"Adora? ADORA!"

***

"Catra! You can talk!" Catra coughed and spluttered:

"Barely. Everything hurts." Adora hugged Catra even tighter. She asked:

"Does that mean you can feel again?" Catra groaned:

"A little bit. You know your knuckles are digging into my back, right?" Adora immediately pulled back from the hug exclaiming:

"I'm sorry! I didn't mean to!" Catra smiled, even though it hurt to do so. Adora was such a dork. What had she done to deserve her?

"It's fine! Don't be an idiot, you can still hug me if you want." With that, Adora climbed onto the bed and lay down next to Catra. She put her arm over her and nuzzled into her mane.

"I'm sorry Shadow Weaver hurt you again." Catra sighed before muttering:

"I don't care. We'll get out of here someday, and then we'll be the ones calling the shots. Shadow Weaver will have no power over us anymore."

***

Bow and Glimmer burst into Adora's room, only to see Catra desperately leaning over her doing chest compressions. Glimmer yelled:

"What happened? What did you do?!" Catra yelled back:

"Nothing! I'm trying to save her!" Bow ran to Catra's side and said:

"I'll take over – go and get the doctor! He's just down the hall!" Catra reluctantly stopped what she was doing, letting Bow take over. She then ran past Glimmer and out into the hall. She noted that there were no guards, and that the nearest window was open and close enough to the ground for her to escape. She thought about it for a moment, but only for a moment. Adora was more important. She had always been more important. Catra ran down the corridor, yelling:

"DOCTOR! COME QUICK! ADORA NEEDS YOU!"

***

Adora smiled at Catra's speech. She loved how ambitious Catra was, not to mention how brave, beautiful, intelligent…Adora literally fell asleep listing the many things she loved about Catra. She could not understand why Catra felt the need to keep saving her, especially when she kept getting punished like this. No one else cared that much about her – they were all resentful of how she was Shadow Weaver's favorite. No one seemed to understand how much pressure she was under – how she was given more work than anyone else and how much more severe the

punishments were if she failed. IF she failed. Catra kept covering for her when she did. Why did she do that? What had she done to deserve Catra?

At some point during her sleep, Catra moved and Adora found herself lying flat on the bed. This should have woken her up, but it did not. She then felt a sharp pain in her chest – a pain which kept going and then returning. It was like a rhythm, and it felt like her ribs were breaking under some external force. Adora fought to wake up, but was finding it exceptionally difficult to do so. She then heard Catra's voice yell:

"I'm trying to save her!" Catra was there and she was in distress. Adora had to wake up now. Using all her strength, Adora opened her eyes and was shocked to see a boy in an archer's outfit performing chest compressions on her. She gasped at the pain of it, and he immediately stopped. He leaned over her and yelled:

"Adora? Adora! Are you okay? Can you hear me?" Adora stared at him in confusion before frantically surveying her surroundings. She was not in the Fright Zone anymore – everything was so bright and colourful. Then an unknown female voice spoke up:

"Adora? It's okay! We're here!" Adora turned her head to see a literal princess on the other side of the room. What had happened? Had she been captured? Kidnapped from the med bay? Why? And where was Catra? Adora sat up and instantly regretted it. She collapsed back on the bed from the pain of her broken ribs. The boy then spoke:

"Take it easy, Adora. It's okay – you're safe now!" Adora growled angrily and then grabbed his shirt, pulling him towards her:

"I don't know who you are or what your game is, but you're going to tell me where Catra is - right now!" The princess then teleported next to the bed and separated them. She held her hands up defensively and said:

“Adora! What are you doing? It’s us! Bow and Glimmer! The Best Friend Squad?” Adora scoffed:

“That’s a stupid name.” She then grabbed the jug of water next to her bed and threw it at them. The princess teleported herself and the archer out of the way, and they materialized in the doorway of the room. The boy then yelled:

“Adora, stop it! We’re your friends!” Adora laughed mockingly:

“I would never be friends with a princess!” She then looked around for a weapon but, before she could throw anything else, a familiar voice rang through the air:

“Adora?” Adora looked back at the doorway to see Catra standing behind the princess and the archer, followed by a satyr in a white coat. She looked different, like the world had ended and she was the lone survivor. Her uniform was different too – it was darker with a very provocative boob window. Adora smiled and gasped:

“Catra! Thank goodness you’re okay!”

***

Catra was beyond confused. When she had left the room mere moments ago, Adora had been at death’s door and had been relying on CPR to stay alive. Now she was sitting up and talking to her? And yelling at Glimmer and Bow? Was she missing something? Had the piece of her mask messed with Adora’s head? The doctor then pushed passed her and approached Adora:

“Okay, Adora – please lie back down. I need to assess your condition.” Adora looked scared and confused. She did not listen to the satyr and instead turned to look at Catra. Realizing she was waiting for her assurance that everything was okay, Catra said:

“It’s okay, Adora. He’s a doctor. He’s just going to make sure you’re alright.” Adora raised her eyebrow at Catra, but seemed to believe her. She lay back down on the bed and let the doctor

perform his check-up. While he did so, Glimmer moved next to Catra and whispered:

“She doesn’t remember us. What did you do?” Catra groaned in frustration before quietly replying:

“Nothing! I did what Entrapta said – I used my mask to wake her up!” Bow then moved next to her and said:

“Well, she needs to know that she’s safe and that we’re not her enemies. Could you go and sit with her until she returns to normal?” Glimmer then groaned and exclaimed:

“IF she returns to normal! There’s no way of knowing!” Bow spoke sternly:

“Glimmer! Not helping!” Ignoring them both, Catra silently walked over to Adora and sat on the bed next to her. Adora looked up at her desperately - utterly confused by what was happening. Catra gave her a reassuring smile and said:

“It’s okay. I promise everything’s okay.”

***

Adora was terrified. She was beginning to wonder whether she was suffering from memory loss. That would explain why the princess and her friend seemed to know her, why she was no longer in the Fright Zone, and why Catra looked so different. Her thoughts were then interrupted by the satyr saying:

“Two broken ribs from the chest compressions. Otherwise you seem completely healthy, Adora. Congratulations!” The doctor then turned to leave, only to have his exit blocked by Glimmer:

“Doctor, before you leave, Adora seems to be suffering from memory loss. Will she get better? Is there anything we can do?” The satyr rubbed the back of his neck and said:

"I really don't know. I don't know what brought on the memory loss. If it was the unconventional cure, it's anyone's guess. If it was the trauma of the situation, however, then I suppose there's a chance…" Bow, noticing that Adora was listening, interrupted him:

"Okay, thank you doctor! We'll call you if we need anything else!" The doctor nodded and left. Glimmer and Bow awkwardly stood in the doorway for a long minute before Adora finally broke the silence:

"Okay - Catra, what's going on? Who are they? Where am I? What happened?" Catra took a deep breath before rubbing a hand through her mane. Adora knew what that meant – she had bad news. Catra asked:

"What's the last thing you remember?" Adora thought for a second before saying:

"The med bay. I was in the med bay with you after Shadow Weaver paralyzed you for saving my life in the training simulation." The princess gasped in shock and the boy's eyes went wide. Catra looked away, presumably reacting to the pain of the memory. She then said:

"That was four years ago, Adora."

***

Catra was trying so hard not to cry. She remembered that night in the med bay so well. It was the first time Adora had slept close beside her, as opposed to the way they normally slept (with Catra lying at her feet). They had only done this a few times, and it had been exclusively in the med bay where not even Shadow Weaver would dare to enter unless she had to.

Catra closed her eyes and sighed loudly. Why did this have to be Adora's last memory? She opened her eyes again, wiped away the tears that started to fall, and then slowly turned back to face Adora, who had been stunned into silence by Catra's statement. Catra was about to speak again when Glimmer suddenly said:

"I know it's a lot to take in, Adora, but I promise we're your friends! We won't hurt you! My name is Glimmer, and this is Bow. Yes, I'm a princess (well, technically I'm a queen now), but, even though you used to be with the Horde, we're best friends and we're just happy you're okay!" Adora's eyes went wide and she turned to Catra:

"'Used to be'? Did I leave the Horde? Did we leave together? Did Shadow Weaver let us?" With that, Catra began to actually cry. How was she supposed to explain that Adora had abandoned her and joined the princesses after only a few hours of knowing them? That the last three years had been spent fighting her - that the anger she felt at Adora's betrayal had pushed her to make so many terrible decisions and hurt thousands of people? She turned to Adora and tearfully said:

"No – I mean, yes. You left the Horde. You also left me. Shadow Weaver went after you, but you beat her. She took it out on me, but…I eventually beat her too." Catra wiped her eyes and took a deep breath. She could not do this. She really could not. Catra then felt Adora gently grab her arm, the way she used to, and she said:

"But, why would I leave you? I love you! We promised to stay together!" This was too much for Catra to handle. She stood up and tore her hand out of Adora's grasp, yelling:

"Oh really? Now you remember the promise?! It's been three years, Adora! It's too late! You may love me, but I don't love you anymore. It's over between us – it has been for a long time. Goodbye Adora." Catra then walked straight past Glimmer and Bow, leaving the room, and doing her best to ignore Adora crying out her name. As she entered the hall, turning back towards the throne room, she heard footsteps approaching. Her heightened senses told her that the rest of the Rebellion were heading her way. Catra closed her eyes and groaned. She could not cope with any more of this – she had to get out. She opened her eyes and looked around her. The window she had noticed earlier was still open. Without a moment's hesitation, Catra jumped out of it.

***

When the princesses approached Adora's room, the first thing they heard was Adora screaming Catra's name. When they entered, they saw Glimmer and Bow trying to restrain Adora from jumping out of the bed. Soon afterwards, the doctor came rushing in to sedate her. Once he had done so, Glimmer and Bow explained what had happened to the members of the Rebellion. They all listened in shocked silence and, when Shadow Weaver's past actions came to light, they all turned to stare at her. Shadow Weaver scoffed and defended herself:

"Adora's special – she always has been. Catra is not. Like me, she has had to earn her place in the world. Her greatness was not handed to her – she had to fight for it. I taught her that and turned her into one of the most fearsome Force Commanders to have ever served under Hordak's command." Glimmer glared at her and said:

"Yeah, well, when I found her she had just defeated Hordak. And she did not care – she wanted me to kill her! You did not train a fighter, Shadow Weaver! You trained a survivor – a scared girl who just wanted someone to care about her!" Glimmer then took a deep breath before continuing:

"This does not mean I condone or excuse her actions. Catra needs to face justice for what she has done. But so do you! Guards!" Before Shadow Weaver could protest, two guards appeared and dragged her away. Glimmer then turned to where Adora lay sleeping and said:

"We need to find Catra. Now."

***

When Adora woke up, she found that Catra was facing her and had her arm over her as well. The paralysis had worn off overnight and, at some point, Catra's wounds had been cleaned and fresh bandages had been applied. Adora marveled at the

gorgeous smile on Catra's face, and her heart skipped a beat with every purr that came from her chest. Adora secretly wished it could always be like this – that she could wake up this close to Catra every day of her life.

Chapter End Notes

If it makes you feel better, I'm crying too.

Catra Meets Madame Razz

Chapter Notes

> Here's the next chapter! The plot's finally picking up a bit! Thank you all for your lovely comments and kudos! They mean so much to me! The next update will be in a few days' time! I hope you enjoy! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra ran and kept running for as long as her legs would carry her. She ran in no particular direction with no destination in mind. All she knew was she had to get away. Adora's cries rang in her head and refused to leave.

Catra finally collapsed in a clearing as the sun started to rise. She realized she must have been running for over an hour. As she struggled to catch her breath, her thoughts once again turned to Adora and she began crying again. It was in that moment that it finally hit her - she had lost everything. The Horde was gone. Any power she once held was no longer hers. She had nowhere to go and no one cared what happened to her. Adora, the one person who might have cared, and the only reason she had fought for so long, was now a shadow of her former self – an emotional wreck who had conveniently forgotten all the pain of the last three years.

Catra envied Adora and hated that all this happened because of her stupid machine. Of course Adora would go to Beast Island to save Entrapta despite everything she had done for the Horde. Of course she would actually listen to Scorpia and agree to help her! Adora was a good friend – she was a good person. She had always been too good for the Horde – too good for Catra. And now she was a mess, just like Catra.

Catra angrily swept the hair away from her eyes, remembering her mask was no longer there as she did so. She growled angrily

at its loss and wiped away her tears. She then tried to get up but quickly fell back down again. Everything hurt. Her legs ached from all the running and her chest felt like it might explode. She then remembered her fight with Hordak and all the injuries she had sustained. How had she managed to ignore the pain of running with broken ribs and an injured leg? How had she even been able to run? Upon realizing all this, Catra officially gave up, lay back down on the cool green grass and closed her eyes. She had nowhere to go and no one was chasing her.

Several hours passed and Catra woke up with a sharp pain in her chest and a complete loss of feeling in her bad leg. The sun was directly overhead and shining straight in her eyes. She cried out in pain as she tried to sit up. Deciding it was not worth the effort, Catra fell back down again. Everything that had happened came flooding back into her head – Double Trouble, the defeat of the Horde, Adora's near-death and memory loss…Catra groaned and covered her face with her hands. At least her arms were still working.

After a long moment wishing she was still asleep, Catra lowered her arms and stared at her surroundings with total disinterest. She was still in the clearing. She had no idea where Brightmoon was, or where the Fright Zone was, and she really did not care. If anyone came to find her, she would just surrender. She was in no condition to fight and had nothing left to fight for. She was completely broken.

As if on cue, Catra's ears suddenly perked up at the sound of footsteps nearby. She closed her eyes and sniffed the air. She did not smell the metal armour of the Horde soldiers, nor the sickening magic of the princesses…blueberries. She smelled blueberries. She then heard a bush rustle as someone walked into the clearing. An old lady's voice then croaked:

"Catra, dearie? Is that you?"

***

When Adora woke up from her sedation, she found she was still in her bed, and her arms and legs were tied down at the sides. She screamed and began pulling at her restraints. This was bringing back some bad memories from her training under Shadow Weaver, and she was not about to let the princesses use their magic on her as well. As she fought to escape, the princess from earlier, Glimmer, teleported into the room and rushed over to her. She leaned over Adora and put her hand on her cheek, saying:

"Hey! It's okay! You're safe! No one's going to hurt you!" Adora stopped moving and growled:

"Release me. Now." Glimmer gave her a sad look and said:

"I'm afraid we'll have to wait for the doctor before that can happen. But don't worry, Adora! You're not our prisoner! You're our friend - we won't hurt you!" Adora raised her eyebrow before scoffing:

"Yeah, right. You're a princess. Princesses hurt people." Before Glimmer could say anything, the boy who had revived Adora earlier came in. He seemed out of breath and looked very pale. He spluttered:

"Adora! Hey! Did you sleep well?" Adora frowned and asked:

"Was I given a choice?" Ignoring her, Bow looked over to Glimmer and said:

"I called for the doctor. He's on his way." Glimmer nodded and then, turning away from Adora, she left the room. The boy's shoulders slumped as he watched her leave. After a moment of awkward silence, he turned back to Adora, forced a smile and came over. He sat in the chair next to her bed and said:

"You've forgotten my name, haven't you?" Adora nodded. He smiled sadly and said:

"It's Bow. That was Glimmer, and we're your best friends. We're the Best Friend Squad." Adora visibly grimaced:

“I remember you saying that. It’s a stupid name.” Upon saying that, however, she was surprised to find herself smiling. She had no idea why. Was it the mere idea of her having friends? Real friends? That reminded her of a certain feline and her expression became grim once more. She stared hard at Bow and asked:

“Where is Catra? Is she also in your Best Friend Squad?” Bow gave a small chuckle before saying:

“I’m not sure she’d want to join, but she’s welcome to!” He then looked away and muttered:

“Actually, she ran away. We don’t know where she is.”

***

Catra opened her eyes and turned to stare at the little old lady with the white hair, pink outfit and butterflies fluttering around her. She tried to hiss, but ended up howling in pain once more. The lady hobbled over and knelt down beside her. Catra was not sure who this person was or whose side they were on. The lady then gave her a reassuring smile and said:

“My, my, dearie! You’ve hurt yourself pretty badly! Well, no need to worry! Madame Razz will help you! Just stay there and don’t move!” As the lady got up and rushed off, Catra whispered:

“Gladly.” She then let herself fall asleep again, believing the entire interaction to have been nothing more than some bizarre fever dream. She was then woken up by someone lifting her head up and pouring a tasteless hot liquid down her throat. Catra almost choked on it, but managed to stop herself when she realized it was the lady from earlier who was giving it to her. She did not seem hostile and was saying:

“That’s right, Catra, dearie! Drink up! This will make you all better!” Too weak to fight her, Catra let the lady pour the whole bowl of whatever it was down her throat. The lady then rested Catra’s head back on the grass and looked away, muttering quietly to herself. Within seconds, Catra could feel her insides burning up.

Convinced that she had just been poisoned, Catra tried to get up and fight the lady, but it still hurt too much to move. After several moments of excruciating pain, Catra passed out once more. As she did so, her mind played one of her worst memories:

"Come with me! You don't have to go back there - we can fix this!" That was the moment Adora chose the princesses over her. And the day Catra chose the Horde over Adora. She regretted that choice now. She really did.

***

"What do you mean she ran away? Where? Why? What did you do to her?!" Adora began to frantically pull on her restraints once more. The one around her right hand was beginning to weaken. Bow leaned forward and reached out his hand to hold hers. The movement surprised Adora, and she calmed down. Bow then said:

"Like I said, we don't know where she is. The princesses are out looking for her right now. As for why, I don't know that either. We did nothing to her, Adora. I promise." Adora narrowed her eyes before sighing and falling back on the bed. Bow's words reminded her of another promise – a promise Catra had said she had broken. But had she really broken it? How could she? Catra was her person. The two of them were inseparable. They loved each other. Or did they? Now she thought about it, Catra had never said it back to her – but she kept sacrificing herself for her, so she must like her, right?

Adora's thoughts were then interrupted by the arrival of the satyr from earlier. He walked over to the bed and told her to keep still while he did some tests. Adora was too tired to argue. Once the doctor finished examining her, he had silently left the room with Bow running after him. Adora could hear their muffled discussion through the door, but she honestly did not care what they were saying. Instead, she tried to process what little information she had been given.

She had been told that she was in Brightmoon and that four years had passed. Apparently, she was now friends with the princesses and no longer friends with Catra. Also, Catra had run away and no one knew where she was. She had been dressed in a Horde uniform, meaning that the Horde still existed. Did that mean Adora really had been fighting against the Horde? Pushing that thought to the back of her mind, Adora tried to focus once more. She remembered seeing a Force Captain's badge on Catra's belt, as well as the Force Commander's diamond on her shoulder. She gasped in realization. That was Shadow Weaver's diamond – not Catra's. Maybe she really had beaten Shadow Weaver. Maybe four years really had passed. Just then, the door opened once more and a man dressed in purple with a black beard came in. He was followed by a beautiful creature with a horn and two large white wings. Before Adora could do anything, it exclaimed:

"Hey Adora! It's so good to see you again!" Adora gasped in horror.

"What are you? Who are you? What's going on?!" The creature looked genuinely hurt at her reaction, making Adora instantly regret it. The man then gave her a smile and stepped closer, saying:

"This is Swift Wind. He's a talking horse. And he can fly. Don't worry, he won't hurt you." Adora could not help but smile back. This person seemed nice, at least. He then sat in the chair next to her bed and said:

"My name is Micah. I'm Glimmer's dad. I was trapped on Beast Island for the last ten years until yesterday, when you came and saved me." Adora gasped:

"Beast Island? It's real?!" Micah smiled and nodded:

"Yep. And, like I was saying, you went there to save me and got blasted by some kind of death ray while doing so. Swift Wind flew you back here and Glimmer got Catra to save you. It seems that, when she did, she may have accidentally erased your memory of

the last few years. Not to worry though – the doctor says you'll remember everything soon! We just need to be patient!" Adora stared wide-eyed at Micah. She had to admit there was something familiar about him, but she could not figure out what it was. Had he been on one of the Horde propaganda posters? One of the really old ones from when she and Catra were kids? Swift Wind then stepped forward and nuzzled Adora's cheek. Her eyes grew even wider. She could not believe she was in close contact with this glorious creature. It then said:

"I'm really sorry, Adora! I should have protected you from the death ray, but I didn't make it in time! I failed you!" It said the last part really dramatically. Adora could not help but smile. She successfully broke her right hand free and hugged Swift Wind around his neck. Even if this was some kind of sick joke, there was no way she was not going to enjoy meeting this "horse". With a smile, she played along:

"It's okay, Swifty. I forgive you." Micah, surprised by Adora breaking free, suddenly got up and raised his hands – ready to attack. Adora raised her eyebrow at him – fully prepared to repel anything he hit her with. Swift Wind was blissfully unaware of the tension and pulled back, happily shaking his mane. He then looked at Adora and said:

"Good! Now the beloved bonds of our friendship have been re-sealed, it's time to discuss the elephant in the room." Adora stared at him in confusion.

"What's an elephant?" Micah sat back down in his chair and said:

"I have no idea. Maybe it's slang for something?" Ignoring both of them, Swift Wind continued:

"I mean it's time to talk about the topic we're all clearly avoiding!" Adora raised her eyebrow.

"You mean the fact I'm still tied to my bed and Micah looks ready to knock me out?" She then turned to Micah and glared at him.

“Do it – I dare you.” Swift Wind then coughed and declared, rather loudly:

“NO! No hitting! No fighting! Adora, we need to talk about She-Ra!”

***

When Catra woke up, she had a terrific headache. There was no more pain, however, and she found she could move her legs. As she sat up, she quickly became aware that she was no longer in the clearing. She was now in what appeared to be a small hut, and was lying on a makeshift bed. She was about to get up and go when she saw the lady from earlier doing something in the kitchen – not far from where Catra was sitting. Running her hands through her mane to calm herself, Catra mustered the strength to speak:

“Okay, Crazy Lady. Who are you and what did you do to me?” The lady seemed startled and turned around instantly. When she saw that Catra was awake, she grinned and rushed over to her. She sat next to Catra and put her hands on her face, as if to check that everything was still in the right place.

“Catra, dearie! You woke up so fast! I can see why Adora likes you! You’re strong, just like her!” Catra pushed away the lady’s hands and gave a low growl.

“Okay, that’s enough! How do you know my name? How do you know Adora?” The lady seemed totally unfazed and picked up the jug of water next to the bed, pouring a glass for Catra. She said:

“Adora is She-Ra. I’m friends with She-Ra. And you’re her wife - of course I know you!” Catra went wide-eyed and then she burst out laughing. This continued for half an hour. The lady, who had now introduced herself as Madame Razz, not only claimed that Catra was Adora’s wife, but that the two had a child named Finn, and that they lived together in Brightmoon. She had also said that Catra was the princess of Half-moon, and that she did not

normally dress in “that horrid Horde uniform.” Catra had raised her eyebrow at that. She thought her uniform looked pretty good, all things considered.

Honestly, Catra now believed that she had been drugged and that this whole thing was some crazy hallucination. None of what this lady was saying was true, nor could it ever be true. But she really had nowhere else to go, and it was genuinely amusing listening to her. When Madame Razz stopped rambling about how terrible the Horde was (Catra was not going to disagree with her), Catra asked her about Half-moon. After a brief pause, Madame Razz explained:

“Half-moon was an ancient underground kingdom in the Whispering Woods. After the Horde arrived and took over the Scorpion kingdom, they attacked Half-moon. Your mother, the queen, sent for help, but it was too late. Half-moon was completely destroyed, along with all the magicats who lived there. It was long thought that the queen and her daughter had perished too, but then you were found in a box outside the Fright Zone. You told me that your mother, having lost faith in the princess alliance, and knowing what Hordak would do to the other kingdoms, left you outside the Fright Zone, hoping you would be safe there. She then went to live in exile in the Crimson Waste.” Catra’s face had gone pale and she was suddebly unable to speak. Madame Razz then turned to her and asked:

“But why are you asking me this, dearie? You’re the one who told it all to me!” Catra finally wheezed:

“How dare you? You don’t know anything about me! Stop doing this - all of this! Tell me the truth! Who are you? Who are you working for? What did you do to me?” While saying this, Catra unsheathed her claws, threatening Madame Razz. The lady simply raised an eyebrow and then bonked Catra on the head with her broom. She then smiled:

“Come now, Catra, dearie! You know who I am! But it seems you’ve forgotten who you are.” Catra growled:

“I know perfectly well who I am. I’m the ex-leader of the Horde and the ex-ruler of Etheria. I’m the big bad villain whose heart’s never been in it. I’m broken.” She then sighed and lowered her eyes, muttering:

“Just let me go.” Catra retracted her claws and slowly got up. Miraculously, she seemed to have been healed, but everything still ached. As she began to head for the door, Madame Razz grabbed her hand, stopping her:

“Wait, dearie! That’s not true! You’re the one who saves Etheria! You and Adora! You need each other! Go to her, she can help you!” Catra gave a small smile and said:

“How perceptive of you, Razz. If only I’d known that three years ago.” She then pulled her hand free and made it to the door. She hesitated once she stepped outside.

“Thanks for helping me, Crazy Lady.” Then, without another word, she headed back into the Whispering Woods.

***

Hordak groaned in frustration. He was in his sanctum, trying to fix the damage caused by his fight with Catra. None of his soldiers had returned. He had sent out a general alert to all his Force Captains, ordering them back to the Fright Zone, but so far none of them had even responded.

Hordak slammed his fist on the table. It was over. He had lost. He was not worthy to return to his brother’s side. He had been bested by the princesses – and by Catra. He had underestimated her and resolved never to make that mistake again. As soon as he was healed from his injuries, he would fix his armour and go and kill her. It would probably be the last thing he ever did.

As he stood staring at his broken arm cannon, which lay forlornly on the countertop in front of him, the room suddenly echoed with what sounded like a thunderous explosion. It came from somewhere far above the sanctum. Hordak looked up, unsure of

what he was expecting to find. Only seeing the ceiling above him, Hordak shrugged his shoulders, deciding it was just more of the Fright Zone collapsing. He then heard another bang. And then another. The bangs continued in rapid succession of one another, to the point that Hordak finally became concerned.

He limped out of his sanctum towards what was left of the Black Garnet chamber. There was no longer a ceiling there, so he would get a good look at whatever it was making the noise. Once he entered and looked up, he was astonished to see what looked like half a dozen space ships hovering over the Fright Zone. He was even more amazed when he was suddenly surrounded by green light and literally teleported to the deck of one of the ships. As he got his bearings and looked around, his attention was immediately drawn to the figure sitting in the throne in front of him:

“Is that you, little brother? I thought you had perished.”

Chapter End Notes

> Would I bring Horde Prime to Etheria when it's not necessary and the Heart of Etheria hasn't even been activated yet? Yes - yes I would ;)

The Super Pal Trio Reunites

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! Thanks again for all the kudos! I can't quite believe how much love this fic is getting! Anyway, here's the next chapter ahead of schedule! The next one will hopefully be up over the weekend! I hope you enjoy! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So, I'm a princess? An actual princess?" Swift Wind nodded. Adora's face was blank. Nothing made sense and yet everything made sense. Four years had passed, Catra hated her, the princesses liked her, she had gone to Beast Island and survived… being a princess was not the craziest thing she had been told. Micah then chimed in:

"Yes, you have a sword that you hold over your head, and then you yell-" Swift Wind interrupted, shouting:

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Micah frowned at him before continuing:

"Um, yes…and then you transform into She-Ra, the legendary warrior princess." Adora began sweating. This was all becoming too real. She wheezed:

"Okay…I'm a princess…I fight against the Horde…I fought against Catra…the girl I love now runs the Horde…" Adora took a deep breath to stop herself from hyperventilating. After a moment, she continued:

"I have one question. Well, several really. First of all, how do I know any of what you say is true? Where is my sword? How does its magic work? And why did I turn against the Horde? What happened to make me leave Catra? And where is Catra? Bow said she ran away – do you know why? Have you found her yet? And can you please untie me?!" Before either Micah or Swift Wind

could respond, a loud bang echoed through the palace. It sounded like it came from far off in the distance. Swift Wind immediately headed to the window while Micah turned to Adora, muttering:

"I don't know, Adora. I don't know the answers to any of your questions. I'm sorry." With that, Glimmer suddenly teleported into the room, yelling:

"Dad! You need to come with me right away! Swift Wind, stay with Adora!" Before Micah could protest, he had been grabbed by Glimmer and teleported away. Swift Wind raised his eyebrow and said:

"Well, that can't be good." Adora scoffed and muttered:

"Guess I'm untying myself then." After a few minutes of awkward grabbing and pulling, Adora had managed to free herself from her bed. She got up and stretched, loving how the tension in her muscles was finally relieved. She then headed over to her desk and began looking through it.

Adora found battle plans, battle orders, invitations to various balls and parties, and an old crumpled note that read "Hi Adora" in Catra's writing. Adora raised her eyebrow. She did not remember Catra giving her this. After a moment staring at it, she pocketed the note and headed to the window.

The view was stunning. She was definitely in Bright Moon. The Whispering Woods stretched out for miles, and she could just make out the Fright Zone in the distance. At least it was still there. Adora then made a decision. She turned to Swift Wind, who had been unusually silent and still this entire time:

"Hey! Do you know where my sword is?" Swift Wind nodded.

"It's in the throne room. Glimmer's keeping it for you until you're ready to use it again." Adora smirked.

"Oh, I'm ready. Can you fly me there?" Swift Wind looked unsure as he spluttered:

"Um, uh, I'm not sure that's a good idea…shouldn't we wait for Glimmer…" Adora interrupted him by slamming her hand on the window sill and yelling:

"Hey! You're She-Ra's steed, right? That's what you said! Not Glimmer's! Mine! You do as I say! Take me to the throne room!" Adora had also found a Force Captain badge in her desk. She had pocketed that too.

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As Catra walked through the Whispering Woods, once again with no clear destination in mind, Madame Razz's words plagued her. She was a princess, her mother had abandoned her to keep her safe, and she might one day marry Adora and have a kid? No, the whole thing was too insane – the lady was completely crazy! But why had she seemed so confident, and how did she know Catra so well? Her thoughts were interrupted by voices and footsteps nearby. Catra ducked and hid behind a bush. Using her heightened senses, she figured out there were two people approaching. She was then able to make out their voices:

"…according to my calculations, she has to be in this area. I've triangulated the location of her badge – we must be getting close!"

"I don't know…we've been looking for hours! Also, if we did find her, would she really want to come back with us? She sent you to Beast Island and I…I left her." Catra gasped. Entrapta and Scorpia. Of course it would be them. She listened as Scorpia stopped walking and sat down. She could hear Entrapta stop walking and start to fidget nervously with her tracker pad. She could never stay still – something Catra understood. Scorpia then spoke:

"Hey…should we even go back? I mean, the princesses are super nice and everything but…I don't know, don't you feel like a bit of

a fraud? Like, even though you're welcome you're not meant to be there? I mean, we're bad people, Entrapta. We did bad things to the princesses. They shouldn't just let us wander around free, right?" There was an awkward silence in which Catra lowered her eyes to the ground.

Catra understood why Scorpia might feel like that, but she knew they were not bad people. Entrapta was a geek who was crazy about robots. She put her passion over her loyalties. Not great, but hardly evil. As for Scorpia, she was the most nauseatingly nice person Catra knew. She was even worse than Adora. There was no way she was a bad person. Catra, on the other hand, was awful. As Catra reminisced about every terrible thing she had made them do for her, Entrapta suddenly coughed and muttered:

"I'm not good with people. I am good at tech. Tech makes sense. People do not. The princesses saved me after I made technology that hurt them. Catra betrayed me after I stopped Hordak from hurting her. And Hordak let me get sent to Beast Island after I helped him build the portal." She took a deep breath before continuing:

"But then Catra saved Adora's life after spending years trying to hurt her. She stood up for you and thanked you after she treated you badly. And she listened to me, instead of ignoring me like last time. I still don't understand Catra, but I think she deserves a second chance. If the princesses can give us one, won't they give her one too?" Scorpia chuckled and Catra heard her stand up:

"You're right! The princesses are crazy and really nice for no reason! We should take full advantage of their insanity and bring Catra back with us as soon as we find her!" Catra rolled her eyes. Suddenly, a loud bang was heard echoing through the forest. It came from far away, but Catra's heightened senses could feel its vibrations through the air. What was happening? Scorpia yelped at the loud noise:

"What was that?" Catra then heard Entrapta run towards where she was hiding, yelling:

“Fascinating! That’s the sound of someone breaking the sound barrier! Maybe it’s another First One’s spaceship!” Scorpia could then be heard running after Entrapta, yelling:

“Spaceship? You mean like that old airship that belonged to my family? The one She-Ra wrecked-” It was then that Scorpia tripped over something and literally fell on Catra. Catra hissed and pushed her off her. She then jumped up and ran away, bumping straight into Entrapta as she did so. Both she and Entrapta fell to the ground rubbing their heads and, for a moment, everyone just groaned in pain. Then Entrapta squealed:

“Yay! We found Catra! This mission is officially a success!”

***

Swift Wind flew Adora through the window of the throne room, startling the two guards there. They immediately left their posts and pointed their spears at Adora. Adora hopped off her steed and announced:

“Hey, there’s no need for that! I’m just here for what’s mine. My sword – where is it?” The guards looked at each other uncertainly before a third voice answered her question:

“It’s behind you, Adora.” Adora recognized that voice immediately – Shadow Weaver. She turned around, saw the sword in a glass case by the wall, and headed over to it. The guards then ran forward, yelling:

“No! Stop! Don’t touch it!” They were then zapped by familiar red electricity, and collapsed to the ground, revealing the prisoner they had been guarding. Shadow Weaver was handcuffed and standing tall in a corner of the room.

Swift Wind gasped in horror. Adora glared at her former mentor, pulled the sword out of its container, raised it above her head, and spoke the words Micah had told her to say. Within seconds, she was taller, stronger, and dressed in a frilly white outfit. She also had a tiara and long flowing golden hair. It felt strange yet

familiar. Her body seemed to be used to this transformation, while her mind was not. Maintaining her show of strength, Adora stepped forward, pointing her sword at Shadow Weaver, and saying:

"Okay, Shadow Weaver, what is going on? Why are you here? How were you captured?" Shadow Weaver's eyes widened and she gasped:

"So it's true – you really have forgotten everything!" Adora growled and began waving her sword threateningly:

"Answer me! Don't think I've forgiven you for paralyzing Catra! She did not deserve that! In fact, she deserves none of the punishments you give her!" Shadow Weaver gave a low chuckle which made Adora visibly grimace:

"Oh Adora, how noble of you to defend her after everything she has done to you." Swift Wind then stepped forward, getting Adora's attention:

"Adora, we shouldn't stay here. Shadow Weaver's evil." Adora nodded:

"I know, Swifty. Let's go." As she moved to get on Swift Wind's back, several more loud bangs were heard in the distance. Adora looked out the window, still not seeing anything. Shadow Weaver then spoke:

"It's Horde Prime. He's found us." Adora turned back to face Shadow Weaver.

"Who's Horde Prime?" Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes as she spoke:

"It's always been Hordak's intention to get him to come here. He managed to get a message through to him not long ago, and now he's finally arrived. He'll destroy everything, Adora. You need to stop him." Adora narrowed her eyes to match Shadow Weaver's.

“Since when do you not want the Horde to win?” Shadow Weaver snarled:

“Since they betrayed me. A lot has happened in the last four years, Adora, but one thing has stayed the same – you. You’re still every bit the leader and fighter I trained you to be. These princesses look up to you. They’ll do whatever you say. Use that power. Activate the Heart of Etheria and defeat the Horde once and for all!” Swift Wind gasped and yelled:

“Don’t listen to her, Adora!” Adora shushed him before asking:

“What’s the Heart of Etheria?”

***

“Wildcat!” Scorpia cried happily as she got up and ran over to Catra. Before Catra could respond, Scorpia had scooped her up in one of her trademark bear hugs.

“I’m so glad you’re okay! We were so worried!” Catra growled and broke free from her grip.

“Yes, I’m here – I’m okay. Now we’ve established that, how about you head back to Brightmoon where you’re being treated like the princesses you are?” Catra then began to walk away. Entrapta called after her:

“But, don’t you want to be treated like a princess too?” Catra groaned in frustration and turned back around.

“Has it ever occurred to either of you that the only reason they’re being nice to you is because they’re using you? Entrapta, how long did it take for the princesses to start asking you for help when you got back from Beast Island? And Scorpia, any chance you were going with Glimmer to activate that weapon she was talking about? I mean, you weren’t with the other princesses and you’re clearly not a prisoner-” Catra stopped herself when she noticed Scorpia’s downcast expression. She had last seen it in a

corridor in the Fright Zone. After a moment of tense silence, she continued:

"What I meant was, neither of you are bad people. But you have done bad things. As soon as the princesses have fixed Adora, and the Horde has been officially defeated, I don't think they'll wait to throw you both in a cell." Scorpia and Entrapta exchanged looks before Scorpia quietly asked:

"Okay then. If we don't go back, what should we do instead?" Catra stared at them in disbelief. Did they seriously want her to lead them – again? She had betrayed them both. Entrapta was right – people made no sense. After a moment thinking about it, Catra spoke to no one in particular:

"I don't know. I've nowhere to go." She then turned to her friends and said:

"Go to Dryl, Entrapta. It's your kingdom – it doesn't belong to the Horde anymore. And Scorpia, the Fright Zone belongs to you. Go and find whatever's left of the Horde. Take them and go back there – fix the place up. Make it what it used to be." Both Scorpia and Entrapta stared incredulously at Catra. After another moment of awkward silence, she turned away once more. Scorpia then yelled:

"No, Catra, wait-" She was interrupted by several more loud bangs in the distance. Catra's ears perked up and she stopped moving. She pinpointed where the noise had come from and, pointing in its direction, she turned to Entrapta and asked:

"Entrapta, what's over there?" Entrapta responded confidently:

"The Fright Zone." Catra raised her eyebrow and smirked:

"Maybe Hordak finally woke up." Entrapta then spoke with barely concealed excitement:

"It's not Hordak. That's the sound of lots of things breaking the sound barrier – meteorites, space ships, who knows? We have to

go and see! Come on, Catra! It's no fun going on scientific missions without you!" Catra gasped and finally brought up the elephant in the room:

"So we're ignoring the fact that I betrayed you and sent you to Beast Island? That I was so mean to Scorpia that she literally ran away?" Much to her surprise, Scorpia gave her a beaming smile and said:

"Did you not hear us earlier? We meant what we said – you deserve a second chance, just like us! Please, Catra?" Catra felt tears welling up once again. She held them in and simply nodded. Entrapta then said:

"Great! Now that's settled, let's go to the Fright Zone!"

***

"So, all that's needed for this weapon to be activated is Scorpia connecting to the Black Garnet? That seems simple enough." Adora had never actually met Scorpia, but she had seen her from a distance and knew she was easy to manipulate. Getting her to co-operate would not be difficult. Swift Wind interrupted her thoughts:

"Adora, no! On Beast Island we learned that once all the princesses are connected to their runestones, all the magic at the Heart of Etheria will channel through you! You will not be able to do anything about it! The magic will destroy you and Etheria!" Shadow Weaver laughed and said:

"Really? Who are you going to believe, Adora? A talking horse or me?" Adora narrowed her eyes even more before growling:

"Neither. I only trust Catra and I'm going to find her. Come on, Swifty! We'll see what she has to say about all this!" Shadow Weaver groaned and shook her handcuffs angrily:

"Oh, don't you get it, Adora? Catra is leading the Horde! She betrayed me and you! She's the one who sent the signal out to

Horde Prime in the first place!" That stopped Adora in her tracks. She thought hard. Catra had said she had beaten Shadow Weaver, and she had worn the diamond of Force Commander… Shadow Weaver was right. What was Adora thinking? Catra would not help her take down the Horde. A stray tear rolled down her cheek. Adora wiped it away before anyone saw. She then turned back to face Shadow Weaver. She made another decision.

"If I free you, can you take me to Scorpia?" Shadow Weaver smiled under her mask.

"Of course."

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Catra's eyes widened as the Super Pal Trio exited the Whispering Woods after barely ten minutes of walking. Had she really been so close to the Fright Zone this whole time? Catra could now see it across the wasteland that separated it from the forest, and, as she scanned the horizon, she could make out about a dozen large objects floating above it. Entrapta began jumping up and down happily:

"I was right! They're spaceships! Aliens have come to visit Etheria! Imagine all the things we could learn from them!" Catra's eyes narrowed. How did they get here? Who even knew Etheria existed outside of this planet? As Entrapta ran up to a skiff that just happened to be lying abandoned nearby, presumably from the Second Battle of Brightmoon, Catra put two and two together. The portal. Horde Prime. He was here. This was not good. As Scorpia fired up the skiff's engine, Catra ran over and hopped on board. She said:

"Hey, we shouldn't do this! I know those aliens – they're not nice! We should stick to my original plan!" Before anyone could protest, two people materialized behind her. Catra turned to see Shadow Weaver leaning weakly against a tree and She-Ra standing next to her. She seemed surprised by her surroundings, and even more surprised to see Catra.

Catra blinked. She did not know what to do. Normally she would jump out and tackle She-Ra, giving the others time to get away, but she was unsure whether Adora was back to normal - and she had never seen her going anywhere with Shadow Weaver before. She-Ra then interrupted her thoughts:

"Scorpia! You need to come with me so we can activate the Heart of Etheria!" Scorpia's eyes lit up:

"Oh yeah! That's what Glimmer wanted me to do before you came back from Beast Island!" Catra looked at her quizzically.

"Is this the ancient superweapon the Rebellion has? They need you to activate it?" Adora cleared her throat before saying:

"Yes. Please, Catra, don't try to stop us." Catra raised her eyebrow before replying mockingly:

"I wasn't going to. If you want to take down Horde Prime, be my guest. Isn't that your job? Saving Etheria?" Adora's eyes went wide. Catra was not going to fight? But she led the Horde! Shadow Weaver was right – she was not to be trusted.

Before Adora could say anything, however, one of the large floating objects began to fly closer to them. It was not long before it was directly above them. Entrapta squealed with delight while everyone else just stared incredulously at the gigantic white spaceship above them. Then, without warning, a green light surrounded all of them, and they found themselves teleported onto the ship, facing a menacing figure on a throne. He looked like Hordak, but had a different outfit, four eyes and dreadlocks. He grinned:

"Ah, so many guests! Welcome!" She-Ra growled and charged at the Hordak wannabe. He remained completely unfazed and simply snapped his fingers. When he did, the floor opened up and She-Ra fell right through it. Catra yelled:

"Adora!" The figure chuckled and the floor closed back up. He then said:

“You must be Catra. My little brother had much to say about you.” Catra glared at him and asked:

“Who are you?” Even though she knew the answer, it was even worse to hear him say it:

“Why, I’m Horde Prime! You called and I answered.” He then stood up and approached, raising his eyebrow at the other three people behind Catra. He asked them:

“And who might you be?” Scorpia stuttered:

“S-Scorpia. Princess Scorpia. A-and this is Princess Entrapta. We’re…um…princesses.” Catra had been frantically waving at her to stop talking. It had taken a while to get the message across. A moan of pain was then heard as Shadow Weaver finally stood up. She then slowly made her way over to Horde Prime, and knelt at his feet. She said:

“My lord, I wish to pledge my allegiance to you. Please, let me stay by your side as you return this planet to its former glory.” Horde Prime raised his eyebrow before grinning even more:

“But of course. All are welcome in Horde Prime’s light.”

Chapter End Notes

> I hate Shadow Weaver. I'm thinking of letting her get turned into a clone. You have until the next update to persuade me not to XD

The Rise And Fall Of Despera

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! Thanks again for all your lovely comments and kudos! Sorry this chapter is late - it turned out a bit longer than I was expecting! Also, I have taken your requests to heart - Shadow Weaver shall meet her end at the hands of one member, if not both members, of our favorite lesbian power couple. I love how you're all such Shadow Weaver haters! XD Anyway, this chapter was super fun to write and I really hope you like it! Do let me know what you think! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sighed as the skiff sped across the Crimson Waste. The two clones accompanying her were silent as usual, and all she could think about were Shadow Weaver's words:

"Interrogate them and find out what the princesses are planning! Force it out of them if you must! Just make sure you have something to tell Horde Prime - or you'll suffer the same fate as Adora." Shadow Weaver had practically cooed that last part. She loved what had happened to Adora.

Two weeks had passed since they had all been teleported onto Horde Prime's ship, and within the first few minutes She-Ra had fallen through the floor and gotten violently knocked out several stories below. That fall would have killed Adora had she not been She-Ra.

When She-Ra's body was recovered, she was unceremoniously dragged to a chamber with a creepy green pool, thrown in and practically fried alive until her mind was blank. Catra had been there for all of it – along with Shadow Weaver. Scorpia and Entrapta had simply been dragged off to a cell. They were still there, and there was a reason nothing had happened to them yet. Catra frowned as she remembered the scene in that room.

She-Ra had been thrown unconscious into the pool. Before long, the pain of the water woke She-Ra up, and she began screaming in agony. Catra's eyes went wide and she begged:

"Stop it! You're killing her!" Horde Prime ignored her and Shadow Weaver snarled:

"Shut up, Catra! This is Horde Prime's will." Catra hissed, tugging at the three clones holding her down. She continued to yell at Horde Prime:

"NO! Stop this – please! Let her go!" Horde Prime had laughed at that, turned to Catra and said:

"Oh, but I thought you didn't care about Adora? You two are enemies, are you not?" Catra had then gasped as She-Ra changed back into Adora, and the cries of pain grew louder and louder. Tears began to roll down Catra's cheeks. She turned to Shadow Weaver, who was beginning to look a little concerned at Adora's suffering. Realizing she still would not do anything, Catra then closed her eyes and made a decision:

"Let her go, and I'll work for you. Did you hear that? I'll work for you! Don't kill her!" Horde Prime had raised his eyebrow at this, snapped his fingers, and two clones immediately began to pull Adora out of the water. Horde Prime then walked over to Catra, cupped her face in his hand, smiling devilishly as he did so, and growled:

"Very well. Prime is merciful." He then pulled back and motioned for his clones to release Catra. He then continued:

"My little brother was incompetent, inadequate, a failure. You defeated him and became the rightful leader of the Horde. Your allegiance is greatly appreciated, child." Catra visibly grimaced at that. She then looked over at Adora, who was panting and shaking nearby. Adora then began to look around – her eyes wide with terror. Horde Prime then interrupted Catra's focus by saying:

"I'll make you my right-hand – my general. You will serve under your former mentor, Shadow Weaver." Shadow Weaver, who had been standing still and completely unrestrained the entire time, bowed low and said:

"Thank you, my lord." Catra growled with hatred. She was right back where she started – she refused to give in so easily. She said:

"Alright, fine. You want me to serve you and my former mentor/ abuser? That's fine – but I want something in return! I don't just want you to spare Adora's life – I also want to you to spare the lives of Scorpia and Entrapta! And I'll need your word as a creepy space emperor that you'll do that!" Catra went white after blurting out the last bit. She had not been able to stop herself. Shadow Weaver's eyes went wide, and, for a moment, no one said anything. Then Horde Prime had chuckled and said:

"Of course, little sister. Anything to ensure you're the head of my army." Catra closed her eyes. Sand started to fly at her as the skiff changed its trajectory, heading for the Valley of the Lost. The clones were still silent and her memories continued to play in her mind.

After Catra had made her deal with Horde Prime, she had accompanied Adora to a room where she was outfitted with some scary looking grey armour. She looked so confused and scared the entire time. She kept looking at Catra, much like she had done in Brightmoon. Catra desperately hoped Adora remembered her, and that not all her mind had been erased.

Once Adora's scary grey armour (which was suspiciously similar to Hordak's) had been fitted, she was given a bright red cape and had her sword returned to her. Catra had almost laughed at her expression as she was given the sword. It was like the first time Catra had brought her a dead mouse as a gift. Horror mixed with awe. As Adora stared at the sword in her hand, Horde Prime smiled and said:

"Rise, little sister. Your name is Despara, and you serve Horde Prime." Adora looked like she wanted to ask something, but thought better of it and simply nodded. She had been unusually silent ever since she had been taken out of the pool. Horde Prime continued:

"Your mission is simple. Find the princesses and their pitiful Rebellion, and destroy them. Shadow Weaver will be your supervisor, and Catra shall accompany you." Shadow Weaver had then interrupted and said:

"But, my lord, surely it would be better to…" Horde Prime raised his hand, motioning for Shadow Weaver to be quiet. He then turned to Catra and repeated himself:

"Like I said, Catra shall accompany you and assist you as you obey my orders. Now, you'll both be taken to your quarters and will remain there until I say so." He then turned and put his hand on Shadow Weaver's shoulder, squeezing it painfully.

"Follow me, little sister." Once he and Shadow Weaver left, Adora and Catra were ushered down three different hallways to a large empty cell. They were pushed in and were locked in with a green force field. Catra simply sighed, having been locked up many times before, but Adora was clearly not used to it and immediately panicked. She screamed and threw herself against the force field. She hit it and fell to the ground in her clunky armor. Upon realizing she could not escape, Adora began hyperventilating and tried to pull her armor off. When Catra realized what she was doing, she sunk to her knees in front of Adora and grabbed her arms. She then said:

"Hey! Calm down! It's going to be okay!" Then, after a second's hesitation, she cautiously pulled Adora into a hug and began to purr. While this had not worked to soothe Adora when she was sick, she could only hope it would work now. She smiled as she felt Adora relax and hug her back.

Catra's memory was cut short when the Valley of the Lost came into view. One of Horde Prime's spires was now right in the middle of it, and the place was practically deserted with only chipped residents. That was something Catra had had to supervise – the distribution and implantation of chips on the necks of Etheria's population. She desperately hoped it had not yet happened to the princesses, and she regularly checked up on Scorpio and Entrapta to make sure it had not happened to them either. Adora had not been so lucky, however.

They lay there hugging for a long time. So long, in fact, that they fell asleep. Catra would not admit it, but she had not had a good night's sleep since Adora had left the Horde.

When Catra woke up, it took her a moment to remember where she was. It took her even longer to remember that she was sleeping on Adora, who was still dressed in her armour. It really did not suit her, and was not very comfortable to sleep on. With that, Catra got up, and this action woke up Adora.

After taking longer than Catra to figure out her surroundings, Adora gasped in fear and tried to scramble to her feet. It was quite an adorable gasp, and Catra had to resist the urge to react to it. Unsurprisingly, Adora slipped on her cape and fell right back down in front of Catra. After a moment of awkward silence, Catra raised her hands reassuringly and said, in the least combative tone she could manage:

"Hey Adora!" Adora raised her eyebrow and then pointed to herself, saying:

"Is that my name? I thought I was Despara?" Catra's face fell as she remembered Horde Prime's words. Looking down at the floor, she muttered:

"Well, you'll always be Adora to me." She then moved backwards and leaned against a wall. Adora did not move and instead looked at her curiously. After another long minute, she asked:

"So, your name's Catra, right? You're supposed to be helping me hunt down princesses?" Catra nodded silently. Adora then took a deep breath and blurted out:

"Okay, quick question – who are they and why do we want to do that? Also, who's Horde Prime? And who was the scary lady standing next to him? Also, where are we? Why are we locked in here? Are you single?" Catra's face went red. Adora did not just say that. Adora seemed to realize her mistake and gasped, waving her hands apologetically:

"I'm sorry! I'm sorry! You're just really hot and I talk a lot when I'm scared." Catra smiled at Adora. How was she ever mad at this dork? She nodded again:

"I know - this is almost exactly how you asked me out the first time." Adora then went red and gasped:

"Wait, I knew you before all this? Before my mind was wiped for… why was it wiped again?" Catra then began to laugh. She could not help it. This whole situation was absurd. Adora looked hurt and confused. Upon noticing her reaction, Catra immediately stopped and reached out to her, shuffling closer so she could touch her arm.

"I'm sorry, Adora. It's just that a lot has happened. To answer your questions, the princesses are the leaders of a planet called Etheria. You and I are from that planet. It's where we grew up. Horde Prime is a war lord who wants to conquer it. The "scary lady" next to him is Shadow Weaver. She works for him, and, unfortunately, we work for her. We are currently in space and I have no idea why we're locked in here. I also don't know why your mind was wiped." Catra then took a breath and asked:

"Was that all your questions answered?" Adora nodded and then gave a cheeky grin:

"You didn't tell me whether you're single or not." Catra's eyes went wide and then she gave the biggest smile she could

manage.

"Yes, idiot. I'm single." Adora's grin grew to an unhealthy size.

"Well then, can I just say you're very beautiful?" This made Catra tear up. Adora was just like she used to be when they first started dating all those years ago. It was painful to remember and even worse to see. Catra quickly turned away and said:

"Thank you, princess, but it wouldn't end well for either of us. I'm even more broken than I was the first time you told me that. Just go back to panicking and leave me alone." Catra then moved all the way to furthest corner of the cell and sat facing the wall. She could practically feel Adora's hurt and confusion at her action, but she did not know what else to do.

Their relationship had fallen apart because of her – because she was simply unable to accept and reciprocate Adora's love like she was supposed to. They'd never really broken up – they had just grown further and further apart, until they were just best friends again. And then Adora had left and it had been the ultimate slap in the face. She had gone from fawning all over Catra to only just remembering she existed after Catra literally came to rescue her. That being said, she could not really fault Adora's decision. She knew now that she was not worth going back for, and that there was no doubt the Horde was evil and that the princesses were the heroes of this story.

"General! We've arrived!" Catra was brought back to the present by the skiff coming to an abrupt halt right next to the spire. She sighed and jumped out, letting herself be led inside by two clones. After climbing some stairs, and going down a couple of winding corridors, she eventually arrived outside a small room. One clone turned to her and said:

"They're in there. Would you like us to come in with you?" Catra shook her head.

“No, thank you. I can handle this. Stay here.” She then opened the door and walked inside. Once she entered, the lights turned on automatically and revealed a familiar face trapped behind a green force field.

“Why hello, Kitten! Long time no see!” Catra glared at Double Trouble. While their hair and outfit showed signs of being subjected to Shadow Weaver’s torture, their overall appearance and demeanor was almost exactly the same as it had always been. Catra did not feel sympathetic, however. She growled:

“Shut up. I need to know what the Rebellion is up to - I know you know! Tell me and I can get you out of here. Don’t tell me, and I’m scratching out your eyes!” Double Trouble gasped in mock horror before bursting into laughter:

“Oh, Kitten, you never cease to amaze me! We both know that I can heal myself from whatever injuries you give me. Physical injuries that is - I am a lizard hybrid after all. Spiritual injuries, however, cut deep into my very soul! Those can only be cured with time, and I fear I do not have much longer to live!” Double Trouble had begun waving their arms dramatically for the last part of their performance. Catra folded her arms in complete disinterest.

“You finished?” Double Trouble gave their snake-like smile.

“Why no, darling. I’m just getting started. I can tell you’re worried about your girlfriend – don’t be. She’s safe with the Rebellion - for now.” Catra narrowed her eyes at them. She had not appreciated the girlfriend remark, nor did she have the patience for Double Trouble’s dramatic pauses. She growled again:

“Care to elaborate on that? Is she better? Did they heal her? What are they planning? Tell me!” Double Trouble raised an eyebrow and murmured:

“Like I said – totally obsessed. What is it with you and Adora?” Catra hissed and punched the force field, scaring Double Trouble

enough that they blurted out:

"Okay! Alright! Adora's fine! King Micah and his Mystacor fan club restored her memories about a week ago. The chip's power's been severed (though it's still on her neck) and they're planning to unleash that super-weapon I was telling you about." Catra raised an eyebrow and then breathed a sigh of relief. She mumbled quietly:

"Good. That's good." Double Trouble then laughed:

"I knew it! You want the Rebellion to win! You're not the big bad villain at all!" Catra's fur stood on end upon hearing that remark, but, after taking a moment to calm herself, she said:

"Actually, I want you to send a message to them." Catra then turned off the force field, removed her old Horde badge from her uniform, and held it out to Double Trouble. It served no purpose now. She said:

"Give this to Glimmer. Tell her to go to the nearest Horde base and use this badge to log on to the system. Once she's in, she'll have access to the missiles in the Fright Zone. Only I had the authority to fire them. Hordak didn't even know they existed." Double Trouble stared wide-eyed at Catra before taking the badge hesitantly.

"I see. May I ask what you want her to do with these weapons of mass destruction?" Catra replied slowly:

"Fire at Horde Prime's flagship. I'll make sure Entrapta and Scorpia are safe. I don't care about myself. This all needs to end and, if the super-weapon fails, there needs to be a back-up plan." Catra then turned and slowly began to walk out. She then paused at the door and said:

"You know, you were right – about everything. Thanks for having the guts to tell me the truth." Double Trouble then coughed and Catra turned back around. Double Trouble looked sad.

"I know I'm right, Kitten. All the more reason for you to recognize your worth and care about dying. I know Adora cares – she wouldn't shut up about you at the party." Catra raised her eyebrow and then gave a shy smile:

"Yeah, she always cared. I never understood why."

"I did. You aren't a bad person, Catra. You're the only reason the Rebellion is still standing. The only reason Adora is still alive. I told you everything because I knew you needed to hear it – unlike your bitch of a mentor." Catra gave a small chuckle:

"Oh yeah, she's a bitch alright. Did she hurt you?" Double Trouble shook their head:

"She-Ra treated me worse." Catra laughed audibly at that:

"Oh yeah! I forgot about that!."

***

Catra felt sick – she hated being teleported. She and Adora, along with about ten clones, had been sent to the middle of the Whispering Woods. The princesses had been sighted nearby and it was their job to search and destroy. Letting the clones go ahead, Catra and Adora lingered behind them silently. They had not said a word to each other since that moment in the cell.

Suddenly, the clone in front of them was hit in the face with a fistful of sparkles. He fell over backwards and another clone ran over, only to get trapped by a net arrow. Catra growled in annoyance. Sparkles and Arrow Boy. Of course. Without hesitation, she jumped over the two fallen clones and landed in a clearing. Catra was then mildly surprised to see not only Glimmer and Bow, but also Mermista, her sea-faring boyfriend, Perfuma, the snow queen/ child (whose party she had crashed), Adora's pet talking horse and that same bearded purple guy from Adora's room in Brightmoon. They were all gathered around a fire, presumably about to eat. Glimmer and Bow were the only ones standing, ready to fight. Glimmer grumbled:

"Really, Catra? Do we have to fight now?" Before Catra could answer, Adora stepped out into the clearing followed by the rest of the clones. Everyone gasped and Adora answered Glimmer's question:

"Yes we do." Bow yelled:

"Adora? Is that you?" Catra chuckled:

"Yep – how do you like the glow-up? Black is so much better than white!" Glimmer then screamed in anger, sending a powerful volley of sparkles at Catra's face. Catra narrowly avoided getting hurt by diving to the ground. As soon as she did, Adora ran forward, swinging her sword menacingly. Glimmer teleported out of the way, but Adora managed to cut Bow on his arm. At this point, everyone else had gotten up and rushed forward. The clones had gone around, however, and were keeping them distracted.

Catra watched in horror as Adora's attack became increasingly desperate. She cut Bow again and very nearly stabbed Glimmer. As Catra scrambled to her feet, twenty more clones suddenly materialized around them and instantly ran to subdue the princesses. Catra watched as they distracted Glimmer and successfully knocked out Mermista and Perfuma. Her attention then turned back to Adora, who had now grabbed Bow by his crop top, and was about to stab him. Without thinking, Catra ran over and put her hand on Adora's arm.

"That's enough, Adora! We won! Drop the sword!" Adora paused and turned to look at her. She did not seem to understand why Catra had stopped her. Before Adora could say anything, she suddenly cried out in pain and collapsed to the ground. Both Bow and Catra watched in horror as her eyes turned green and Horde Prime's voice spoke through her:

"I'll decide when it's enough! All the princesses and their followers must die!" Adora then stood back up and turned to face Bow. In doing so, her hair moved and Catra saw the chip on her neck. She

knew that that must be how Horde Prime was controlling her. As Adora raised her sword to kill Bow, Catra leapt on Adora's back and punched her hard on the neck. Adora screamed and fell to the ground. Everyone stopped fighting and turned to stare at them. Adora then seemed to recover and Catra heard Horde Prime's voice again:

"Oh little sister, I'm very disappointed in you." Adora then pushed her off her and spoke the words Catra had hoped she would not say:

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora instantly changed back into her frilly white outfit, only this time her eyes were green. Catra's mind raced back to the Northern Reach and the corrupted She-Ra that had tried to kill her there. She growled and jumped on She-Ra's face. This de-stabilized her. She fell next to where Bow was lying and grabbed him again. She held her sword at his throat and laughed:

"Hahaha! You failed, Catra! Prime sees all! Prime knows all! There's nothing you can do-" Her words were cut short by Catra's lips on hers. Believe it or not, Catra had thought about this. If anything was going to wake Adora up, it was going to be Catra finally doing the thing she had never been able to do before – actually returning Adora's affection. She was right. Not only did She-Ra drop her sword, but she practically melted into the kiss and wrapped her free arm around Catra to draw her closer. Poor Bow was squeezed between them, but he managed to get free and run back to the others. She-Ra then changed back into Adora and pulled back from the kiss. She looked so confused. She muttered:

"Catra?" Catra then said:

"I'm sorry, Adora." She then grabbed She-Ra's sword and knocked her out with it. When Catra looked up, the entire Rebellion, along with all fifteen of the remaining clones, were staring at her in total shock. Catra simply smiled and said:

“What? I wasn’t going to let her kill Arrow Boy!” With that, Bow jumped up and gave her a hug. Catra was completely caught off-guard, but ultimately decided to accept it. As the princesses finished off the clones behind them, Bow said:

“Thank you. And don’t worry, we’ll take care of her.” Catra gave a wry chuckle and said:

“You better!” With that, she broke free of the hug, and ran as far away from the battlefield as she could. She could see the flagship approaching, ready to teleport her back. She had to lure it away from Adora, and give the Rebellion a chance to move her. It was not long before the familiar green light surrounded her and she was pulled skyward once again.

Chapter End Notes

So, does Horde Prime just let Catra get away with that? How is she interrogating DT a week later like nothing happened? These are questions I'm asking myself because I've no idea and I just love writing myself into a corner. Don't worry, though! I killed off Catra about three times in my other fic and always brought her back semi-convincingly! I'll figure it out and it'll be epic(ally good or bad - either way you'll appreciate it)! XD

"Please Tell Her...I'm Sorry. For Everything."

Chapter Notes

> Here you go! Sorry it took longer than expected! As always, thank you so much for the kudos! They mean so much to me! I hope you like this chapter - it's a slightly different style to the others but should still be easy enough to follow. Feel free to comment if you have any questions! I hope you enjoy! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra knew what it would feel like before she hit the water. She knew what it would feel like the second Horde Prime had narrowed his eyes and motioned for her to be dragged away. A lifetime of electrocution had prepared her for this moment, and she endured the pain much longer than Adora had been able to. However, like Adora, she eventually gave in and let her mind go. The last memory that played was that of a young Adora looking into her eyes lovingly and saying:

"You look out for me and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other." Catra gasped in the water:

"You promise?" She then saw a grown Adora smiling at her, saying:

"I promise." Catra smiled as her world faded to black.

***

When Adora woke up, she was surrounded by princesses in some kind of tent. She screamed and pulled at her restraints, unable to break them. That was when a man with a black beard and purple outfit approached, put his hands on her head and, along with several other people in long colourful robes, began to cast a spell. Adora screamed again and tried to resist, but it was no use. Her vision became blurred and she passed out.

Adora then woke up several hours later. This time her only bedside companion was a giant horse with wings, who was also asleep. Adora tugged at her restraints once more and felt the one around her right hand begin to loosen, but then the horse woke up. Adora raised an eyebrow as she tried to remember how she knew what kind of creature now stood before her. She had never seen it before, and it had definitely not been mentioned in the mission briefing. The horse then began to whinny happily, exclaiming:

"Hey, you're awake! Welcome back, Adora!" Adora grunted in confusion:

"You…you can talk?" The horse gave such a frustrated groan that Adora regretted voicing her thoughts.

"No, not this again! Come on, Adora! Don't you remember me? Micah did a spell on you! It should've brought back your memories!" Micah? The guy with the purple robes? Adora then groaned in pain as her head began to hurt from the effort of her remembering. At this point, two more people ran into the tent – a sparkly girl dressed in pink with a blue cape and an archer with a literal heart on his outfit. The girl exclaimed:

"Adora! You're awake!" The boy then asked:

"How're you feeling?" They seemed so friendly and familiar – Adora could not help but smile. She could not quite remember who they were or what was going on, but she knew she was safe and that they were her friends.

"I'm okay. My head hurts, that's all."

***

Catra's head hurt so much. She did not know where she was or how much time had passed since her forced baptism, but the pain was so intense that she did not care. As far as she could tell, she was in a cell on Horde Prime's ship. She was lying on the ground, handcuffed to the wall.

Slowly, Catra moved her hand to feel her head. It hurt to move, but she had to figure out if she was bleeding. She was not, but her head did feel different. Catra gasped when she realized her hair was shorter. It was not just shorter, it was cut short.

Beginning to panic, Catra looked down and was shocked to see that she was in a clone's outfit rather than her usual uniform. What had happened? What was going to happen? Why was her last memory that ghastly pool of electrical water? Her questions were soon answered, but not the way she wanted. The green force field of her cell suddenly disappeared to reveal Shadow Weaver. She growled:

"Hello Catra. It seems you have once again escaped punishment. How do you do it?"

***

A couple of days had passed since Adora had been saved by the Rebellion. She remembered everything now, and it had taken her a while to process. Adora had profusely apologized to everyone for what she had done to them after Beast Island, and while working for Horde Prime. Of course they had all forgiven her instantly, but Adora could not bring herself to do the same. How could she have messed up so badly? She shuddered to think of Scorpia and Entrapta still on Horde Prime's ship, and Catra…Adora punched the wall of the building she was supposed to be searching.

The Rebellion were looking for survivors in Elberon after Horde Prime had destroyed it. Those who had escaped were gathered in the forest, already preparing a feast to thank the princesses for their help. They simply would not take no for an answer. Neither would Catra, apparently. Adora grimaced at the memory.

Catra had saved her. She had saved Bow. She had literally sacrificed herself for the sake of the Rebellion. Why would she do that? Why now after having refused to join them for so long? And why had she raced to her side to help her when she was sick?

Adora had genuinely thought Catra hated her. But then she kissed her, the girl who she now knew she had never stopped loving… she loved her too. Or maybe it had just been a desperate ploy to wake her up? After all, she had not said "I love you", she had said "I'm sorry."

Adora hit another wall, imagining all the implications of that. Why was this so complicated? Why were they so complicated? That was when Frosta screamed and Adora looked out to see the villagers beginning to encircle the princesses menacingly. The one closest to her had a chip like hers on their neck. Adora growled as she ran outside the save her friends yet again.

***

It had been two days since Catra had been re-instated as general, given her uniform back and briefed on her new mission. She now had to interrogate Scorpia and Entrapta, in order to find out about the Rebellion's super-weapon. Horde Prime had learned about it from Catra's memories, and he had sent her to talk with them as a clone. It had not had the desired effect, however. Scorpia had said she would only talk to Catra, and not while Horde Prime was controlling her. Entrapta, on the other hand, had completely frozen in fear and said nothing.

After consulting Shadow Weaver on the benefits of also throwing the two princesses in the pool, Horde Prime had decided it would be more efficient to simply bring Catra back and get her to extract the information after being suitably traumatized by what had happened to her. What Catra could not figure out, however, was why Shadow Weaver was not divulging any information about the weapon. She definitely knew more about it than she was letting on.

Catra was currently heading towards the princesses' cell for their daily interrogation. Scorpia had already told her that her connecting to the Black Garnet was somehow a necessary part of the activation process, and Entrapta had confirmed that, explaining that once their connection was established, the weapon

would automatically fire. She had also said that She-Ra would be the one who fired it.

Upon hearing that this super-weapon would put Adora's life in danger, Catra decided not to tell Shadow Weaver. After all, her experience under Horde Prime's control had not traumatized her as much as making her even more resolved not to help him. Catra had instead reported that she would need more time, and her former abuser had believed her, for now.

When Catra walked into the cell, she was greeted by Entrapta squealing in delight:

"Yay! You're here!" Scorpia then turned and smiled:

"Hiya boss!" Catra had smiled right back at her before tentatively revealing the board game she had brought in with her.

"I seem to remember you wanting to do this a while ago?" Scorpia's face lit up and she tearfully exclaimed:

"You remembered! Oh wow! You're the best, Wildcat!"

***

"Look, I'm not Prince Peekablue, alright? I can't tell you what's going to happen, or whether or not your friends are still alive!" Glimmer growled and shoved harder Double Trouble against the wall.

"I can see that you aren't the prince! I also know that you serve the winning side, which, at the moment, is Horde Prime. You must know something! Tell us or you'll regret it!" Before Double Trouble could respond, Adora came rushing in, followed by Mermista and Sea Hawk. Adora yelled:

"Guys, we need to leave now! Apparently Sea Hawk burnt everyone's ships!" Bow raised his eyebrows before noticing Sea Hawk's nervous wave in their direction. He sighed and asked:

"Okay, I got to ask, just how many ships have you set on fire?" Before Sea Hawk could answer, Mermista groaned loudly:

"One, okay. I've set only one ship on fire! It's not a big deal!" Then the room filled with angry shouting as the backstage door was kicked down and around ten thugs ran inside, heading straight for the sea princess and her not-boyfriend. Adora groaned in frustration before raising her sword and yelling:

"For the honour of Grayskull!"

***

Shadow Weaver stared at the screen in front of her and hissed angrily. Almost four days had passed since Catra had been freed from her clone state, and Catra had spent most of that time with Scorpia and Entrapta. The rest of it, she had unfortunately had to spend reporting to Shadow Weaver and, today, Shadow Weaver had decided to finally confront her on her lack of results.

They were both standing in a giant room which had become Shadow Weaver's base of operations. Despite the defining colour of Horde Prime's ship being white, the room was extremely dark and about as shadow ridden as the Black Garnet chamber. There was no one else in the room besides Catra and her former mentor, and the giant screen suspended from the ceiling showed a live feed of Scorpia and Entrapta's shared cell. Shadow Weaver turned to Catra and yelled:

"I'm tired of waiting, Catra! I need results! Horde Prime needs results!" Catra said nothing. There was a time when Shadow Weaver yelling at her would have provoked feelings of fear, anger, confusion and even self-loathing, but now she felt nothing. The past few days hanging out with Scorpia and Entrapta had actually been really good for her, and Catra no longer felt the need to prove herself. Shadow Weaver growled in frustration and hit the table in front of her. Catra burst out laughing. It was hilarious how little power her former abuser actually had.

***

The Rebellion were gathered in the new war room – a tent in the center of their camp in the Whispering Woods. Glimmer and Bow were arguing about the Heart of Etheria and whether or not they could still, or at least try to, activate it. Adora sat in the corner quietly, running her finger along the edge of her sword. She had heard this fight many times before, and it had really started to interfere with the Best Friend Squad's dynamic. Tuning out the raised voices, Adora reflected on her restored memories.

She remembered Catra telling her that she abandoned her, but, unlike that moment in her room in Brightmoon, Adora could now remember the actual moment she had been referring to: Thaymor. Adora remembered the carnage that day – a civilian town razed to the ground based on the lie that it was a military outpost. She could not believe how naïve she had been. The Horde was evil. It had always been evil. She need only have paid better attention to how Catra was treated on an almost daily basis, instead of believing Shadow Weaver's lies that she deserved it, and that the punishments were only making her stronger.

A tear rolled down Adora's cheek. She had left Catra, and she now understood just how callous she must have seemed asking her to come with her as if she had not been the main reason Adora had been so conflicted about joining the Rebellion in the first place. Deep down, however, she knew she had made the right choice. She could never have gone back to Horde. And, while she could see why Catra would think she abandoned her, she had not. Not really. She had given her plenty of chances to join her, and had never gone out of her way to hurt her. It has always been Catra who escalated things. Her thoughts were then interrupted by Netossa running into the tent:

"Guys, we just got word from the Crimson Waste! Double Trouble's been captured!"

***

Catra walked up to Horde Prime's throne nervously. She usually reported to Shadow Weaver – not him. At first, he did not look at her and remained focused on whatever the clone next to him was saying. As she got closer, she realized it was Hordak. Catra gasped audibly. She had seen him before, but she could still not get over how much Horde Prime had changed him. The gasp got Horde Prime's attention, and he turned to look at her. He then smirked and said:

"Hello, little sister. I've not seen you since your haircut." Catra grimaced. She was so glad she did not remember that. Horde Prime continued:

"You went down to the Crimson Waste to interrogate that rebel insurgent, Double Trouble. I have now received reports that they've escaped. What happened?" Catra gulped and said:

"They told me about the super-weapon, how the princesses are preparing to fire it as we speak. I rushed back to warn you and must have forgotten to seal the cell. My apologies." Horde Prime raised his eyebrow before growling:

"Yes, well, speaking of the super-weapon, it's been six days since I ordered you to get information about that from our guests. Shadow Weaver tells me you have learned nothing despite being granted this generous amount of time. Is that true?" Catra took a deep breath and said:

"Okay, look - I need to win them back in order to get them to tell me anything. I effectively chased Scorpia out of the Horde, and I betrayed Entrapta. You know this! You also know that torture won't work on them. Entrapta simply cannot talk when she feels physically threatened, and Scorpia literally has an exoskeleton. Do you have any idea how impenetrable that is?" Horde Prime raised his hand, indicating for Catra to stop talking. Catra was surprised to find herself out of breath – so determined was she to protect her friends. Horde Prime then stood up and approached her. Once he was close enough, he cupped her chin and stared into her eyes, speaking menacingly:

“Do you know what’ll happen to you if I find out you’re lying?” Catra held his gaze and muttered:

“The same thing that happened to Adora? Didn’t you already do that to me?” With that, Horde Prime roughly pushed Catra to the ground and roared:

“Insolent child! I show you mercy and yet you’re still ungrateful! Yes, I gave you peace and let you into my light! I only pulled you out because I required you as you are now in order to extract the information I need! But, do not think for a minute that I’ll not turn you into my new Despara if I feel that’s all you’re good for!” Catra’s eyes went wide. Now she understood the full extent of the threat. Adora had not simply been turned into a clone. She had been turned into a killing machine who was fully conscious while Horde Prime controlled her. Before Catra could follow that thought to its conclusion, Horde Prime turned back around and returned to his throne.

“You have one hour. Get the princesses to talk, or else.” Catra picked herself up before muttering:

“One hour is all I need.”

***

Double Trouble clutched the rudder of the skiff as if it was their only possession. While it technically was, it did not change the fact that the fate of Etheria once again lay in their hands. This was an unfortunate side effect of being so incredibly awesome. As they neared the Rebellion’s camp in the Whispering Woods, they hit the brakes and narrowly avoided crashing into a tree. Despite being a great actor, they were not the world’s best driver.

As Double Trouble hopped off the skiff, Glimmer materialized before them. She hugged them and said:

“Double Trouble! Oh my…what happened? We heard you were captured!” Double Trouble gave their signature snake-like grin and said:

“Aww thank you, your majesty! Your concern is so touching! Believe it or not, I was having a thrilling adventure in the Crimson Waste (where you sent me to infiltrate Horde Prime’s army). Unfortunately I was found out, and that witch Shadow Weaver paid me a visit. I’ve had more pleasant encounters, let me tell you.” Glimmer raised her eyebrows in concern, and was suddenly joined by Bow and Adora. Bow cried:

“Double Trouble! You’re back! How are you?” Double Trouble smirked:

“Well, hello archer. Always a pleasure to see you. You too, She-Ra!” Adora narrowed her eyes. She did not trust this person, and could not understand how easily everyone else had suddenly become so friendly with them after they had joined their side. Her friends had to know it was just because they saved their life at the undersea party. It was not as if Double Trouble actually believed in their cause. They then continued talking:

“As you can see, I’m alive and well despite everything. However, let me tell you that my daring escape was not all my own doing! I was assisted by a certain feline.” Adora’s face lit up and she stammered:

“C-Catra’s alive?” Double Trouble nodded before smirking again:

“Oh yes! New uniform and new haircut, but still as sexy as ever.” Adora frowned in a mixture of anger and elation. Glimmer then growled:

“Stop that! Leave Adora alone!” Double Trouble then moaned:

“Hey! No fair! I was telling the truth!” Adora then stepped forward and said:

“Well then, keep telling the truth! What did you learn?” Double Trouble smiled once more and reached into their pocket to produce a Horde badge. Adora recognized it immediately. Double Trouble then turned to Glimmer and said:

"Catra has a message for you, your majesty."

***

Catra ran down the corridors of Horde Prime's ship, the alarm blaring in her ears as she did so. Scorpia and Entrapta followed close behind her. She had told Double Trouble she would get the princesses off the ship before Glimmer could fire the missiles, and she had meant it. They turned another corner before running straight into the teleportation chamber. Catra did not hesitate to take out the one clone manning the controls. She then sealed the doors and turned to her two friends:

"Get on the teleportation pad! Quickly!" Entrapta obeyed her immediately, but Scorpia was slower to move.

"What about you, boss? Are you coming with us?" Catra shook her head.

"Not this time. Come on, Scorpia, let me save you!" Scorpia gasped and Entrapta squealed fearfully:

"But, if you stay here, there is an almost zero-percent chance that you will survive!" Catra groaned in frustration before yelling:

"You had even less chance of surviving on Beast Island! And Scorpia risked everything when she went to the princesses to save you! That was all my fault! Now, I've already risked it all for Adora and her friends! Let me do it for you too! Let me save *my* friends!" With that, Scorpia teared up and ran over to Catra, wrapping her in a bear hug.

"You're amazing, Wildcat! In case, I didn't say it before, I totally forgive you for everything! You're not broken anymore – you're all fixed!" Entrapta then yelled:

"Yeah! What she said!" Scorpia then pulled back and slowly walked back over to the teleportation pad. As soon as they were both standing on it, Catra sealed them in and began to type in co-ordinates. As she did so, Horde Prime's clones began to throw

themselves against the doors, trying to pry them open. She yelled over the noise:

"I'm sending you to the Fright Zone! Connect to the Black Garnet and unleash the super-weapon! Then go and find the Rebellion! Adora's with them! Please tell her…I'm sorry. For everything." Before the princesses could say anything, Catra sent them on their way. A few seconds later, she was pinned down on the floor by four clones.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry if Catra's redemption arc seems a bit rushed - I'm just trying to get our two favorite lesbians reunited and kissing again as soon as possible! And yeah, things are definitely going to get more intense in the next chapter. Shadow Weaver may even get beat up, you never know...

Catra Dies...?

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! Sorry this update took so long - I've had a rather busy week! Anyway, here's the super intense chapter I promised! I had so much fun writing this! I hope you aren't all too traumatized by the end! XD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was dragged before Horde Prime's throne. She was unceremoniously dumped at the tyrant's feet, her hands tied behind her back, and his foot under her chin - forcing her to look at him. She hissed. He looked into her eyes and growled angrily:

"What. Is. Wrong. With. You?" Catra smirked:

"Lots of things. How long have you got?" With that, Horde Prime leaned down and slapped her. As Catra recovered from the sting of the hit, she heard Shadow Weaver's screams of protest in the distance. She turned and saw her former mentor dragged towards her, also tied up. Shadow Weaver was yelling:

"Please, my lord! I've done all you asked! Have mercy!" She was then forced to her knees next to Catra. Catra could not help but laugh at her pathetic state. Her hair was disheveled and her clothes were ruffled from where the clones had grabbed her. Horde Prime laughed evilly:

"Really? You've done what I asked? I ordered you to manage Catra and you completely failed! Be thankful I'm not ending you here and now!" He then turned to the clones behind her and said:

"Take her away!" With that, Shadow Weaver was pulled to her feet. In a desperate effort to fight back, she grabbed onto Catra's arm with her tied hands, perhaps hoping that, despite everything, she might still defend her. Shadow Weaver was greatly mistaken, however. She had not counted on Catra having a week of therapy

and hugs. There was no way she would be so easily manipulated. Not again. Instead, Catra leapt to her feet and kicked Shadow Weaver to the ground.

Once Shadow Weaver was down, Catra, despite having her hands tied too, managed to get her claws to reach Shadow Weaver's face, and successfully scratched it in defiance. Not only did this action remove Shadow Weaver's mask, but it provoked one of the most blood-curdling screams Catra had ever heard. Unsurprisingly, Horde Prime made no move to stop Catra, and simply smirked as Shadow Weaver tried and failed to hide her nightmarish face with her hair. Blood from the cut began dripping onto the floor, and even Catra had to gasp at the gravity of what she had done. Horde Prime interrupted her thoughts:

"Did you not hear me, brothers? Take her away!" With that, Shadow Weaver was led away, and Catra had a feeling she knew exactly where she was headed. While Catra was smiling at the prospect of Shadow Weaver finally getting electrocuted herself, Horde Prime suddenly growled:

"Alright, little sister - you've had your fun. Now tell me, where did you send the princesses?" Catra glared at him. She had deleted the destination from the logs before the clones had got her. She remembered the last few seconds before she had sent her friends to safety. She had told them to get to the Black Garnet. She had also told them to get a message to Adora. She knew how those two orders contradicted each other. Entrapta had told her how the Heart of Etheria would put Adora's life at risk, but Double Trouble had said the Rebellion was still planning to fire the weapon; which meant they were either lying or Adora really was back to normal and playing the hero again.

Catra sighed. She knew Double Trouble had not been lying. Not this time. And if the weapon was going to be fired anyway, what was the use in trying to stop it? All she could do was hope it finished Horde Prime off like it was supposed to, and that Horde Prime learned nothing of it. Of course, this meant he could not be allowed to turn her into a clone again. It meant she would have to

anger him enough for him to kill her. She doubted even he had a way of bringing back the dead. Horde Prime then interrupted her thoughts again by yelling:

"Answer me, Catra!" Catra smiled:

"Wow, you used my actual name. Was that so hard?" Hordak then marched forward and, grabbing her hair with one hand, pulled her up to his height. It hurt so much, but Catra managed to stop herself from screaming. Hordak then growled:

"How dare you speak that way to Prime? He's the ruler of the universe!" Catra gasped in pain:

"Oh, is that all?" Hordak roared in anger and threw Catra some distance away. Horde Prime then stood up and yelled:

"That's enough! Stand down, brother!" As Catra picked herself up, she discovered that her hands were now free, and that she seemed to be holding a purple First Ones' crystal. Had Hordak just cut her free with it? Why? She then looked around and realized she was not surrounded by clones. In fact, Horde Prime and Hordak were the only other people there. Catra grinned malevolently. Maybe her death could wait – this was too good an opportunity to miss.

***

When Scorpia and Entrapta materialized in the Fright Zone, they had no idea what to expect. They certainly did not think they would be face to face with Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio.

As soon as the princesses appeared before her, Lonnie raised her baton and screamed:

"What the hell?! Put your hands up! Don't move!" Scorpia immediately raised her claws in surrender:

"Done and done! Please don't shoot - it's us!" Entrapta simply smiled and used her hair to wave at the squad:

"Hi!" Lonnie slowly lowered her baton and motioned for her friends to do the same. She then said:

"It's okay, Scorpia – you can put your claws down." Scorpia breathed a sigh of relief and did just that. Rogelio then began to growl. Lonnie responded to him:

"Yes, I'm about to ask!" She then turned back to the princesses and demanded:

"Okay, Scorpia, what's going on? Where did you come from? What is *she* doing with you?" Entrapta was confused at the hostility with which she was referred to, but Scorpia soon explained:

"Lonnie, Catra lied about Entrapta - she didn't betray us! That's why I left – I had to save her from Beast Island!" The squad looked at her with blank expressions before Lonnie's eyes narrowed:

"Of course Catra lied about it! Why wouldn't she? It's just like I said – she never cared about us!" Scorpia gasped and said:

"No, no! She does care! She's the one who sent us here! She risked her life to save us!" Entrapta then said:

"Yeah, and Horde Prime's probably killed her already!" Scorpia's face went white with horror. Kyle also went pale before asking:

"Wait, Horde Prime? You guys were on Horde Prime's ship? And Catra saved you?" Both Entrapta and Scorpia nodded. Rogelio then crossed his arms and nudged Lonnie with a low growl. Lonnie, who had been too stunned to say anything, finally sighed and said:

"Yeah, I know they're not lying." She then looked back at the princesses and asked:

"Well, why did she send you here? Did she think the Horde would protect you after everything you both did or *did not* do?" Scorpia raised an eyebrow in confusion:

"What? No - she sent us here so I could connect with the Black Garnet and help activate the Rebellion's super-weapon. Why? Is the Horde here?" Lonnie nodded to Scorpia's question. Kyle then asked:

"What super-weapon? I thought the princesses were bad, why does Catra want to help them?" Entrapta then lifted herself up with her hair and shouted:

"Okay, look, Catra was bad but now she's good! And Horde Prime is way worse than she was! Catra wants him gone, and only releasing the Heart of Etheria can do that! That's why we're here! So let's go to the Black Garnet chamber!" Everyone was stunned into silence. Lonnie then sighed again and said:

"Okay, fine! Follow me and keep your voices down. I really don't want to have to explain this to the others."

***

Glimmer sat at the control panel of the old Horde base the Rebellion had been using as a hideout. It was actually the old pulse-bot factory that she had wrecked while fighting Catra, but she would never admit that. She took Catra's badge and, just like Double Trouble had said, the screen lit up when its mere presence was detected. An automated female voice then said:

"Welcome, Force Commander Catra. What are your orders?" Glimmer stared at the screen in confusion. Everything was in code – presumably because everything in the base had been smashed to pieces. It was a wonder the screen was working at all. Adora then stepped forward and said:

"It's okay, I got this." She gently pushed Glimmer out of the seat and then sat down herself. She recognized the code – it was an automated distress signal going out to all Horde units in the area. The badge had activated it. Adora quickly turned it off and the screen went blank once more. While she was relatively certain that there were no Horde troops in the area (or anywhere for that

matter), it was entirely possible that Horde Prime's bots could track the signal. Once she was certain the computer was no longer transmitting, Adora began to type once more.

After a few seconds, the screen showed Adora a menu with a list of options. Adora wasted no time in searching for the missile activation programme. As she expected, it was exceptionally difficult to find. However, with her knowledge of Catra's passwords and the Horde's computer system, she eventually succeeded in doing so. Unfortunately Adora did not have time to congratulate herself. All the princesses, herself included, suddenly began to glow.

***

Catra swiped at Horde Prime. She had already knocked out Hordak who, despite supposedly helping her get loose, had charged at her the second she had stood up. Catra was now poised on top of Horde Prime's throne, with the galactic emperor stumbling backwards in surprise. Catra then jumped on him, forcing him to the ground. He cried out in pain before pushing Catra off him. Catra quickly regained her footing and, using every ounce of her strength, pushed Horde Prime off the side of the platform. He screamed and desperately clung to it with one hand. He cried:

"Please, little sister, don't do this!" Catra simply laughed before snarling:

"Goodbye *big brother*! I'm not going to miss you!" She then wrenched his hand free with her foot. He screamed as he fell, and Catra gave a small grin of satisfaction. She had done it. She had saved the day. It was then that she remembered the Heart of Etheria was about to be activated, not to mention the imminent launch of the Horde missiles. With a grunt of annoyance, Catra ran to the control panel. For some reason, no clones had entered the room. She found this odd as Horde Prime had surely been telling them what was happening telepathically.

Once Catra reached the control panel, it became obvious that something was wrong. The screen was flashing with a muted alarm. Upon further investigation, Catra discovered it was informing her that a portal was being opened. She gasped in horror. Was that the secret weapon? Had no one learned anything from the last time this happened? Entrapta had not told her about this – had she known? Had she simply forgotten to tell her? She must have done.

Catra then heard a groan, and turned to see Hordak rubbing his head. She quickly turned back to the control panel and, using her new Horde badge (the one Horde Prime had given her), bypassed the ship's security and ordered it, and all ships linked to it, to self-destruct.

Catra would not deal with another portal. She could not. She only hoped that Adora would handle it like she had last time. That being said, there was no way Horde Prime and his army were still going to be here when she did – not if Catra had anything to say about it. Catra's thoughts were then interrupted by Hordak grabbing her foot and pulling her down to the ground.

***

Scorpia had collapsed on the ground of the Black Garnet chamber, gasping in pain. Entrapta was hovering over her, crying out in concern:

"Scorpia? SCORPIA?" There was strange red smoke coming off her, floating upwards. The squad were all standing still, staring wide-eyed at what was happening. Rogelio then ran forward and, using all his strength, sat Scorpia up against the wall. He then turned to his friends, growling loudly. Lonnie then sprang into action. She ran to the corner of the room and grabbed a first aid kit that had apparently always been there. She then turned to Kyle and yelled:

"Kyle, go! Get help!" Kyle nodded and stammered:

"R-Right!" As he ran out of the room, the sky lit up. The ceiling of the Black Garnet chamber had long since collapsed (during the fight between Catra and Hordak) and Entrapta looked up in astonishment before shouting excitedly:

"It's another portal! The Heart of Etheria has been activated! We're being pulled through!" Lonnie, who had now made it back across the room, yelled:

"Through to where?" Without waiting for an answer, Rogelio grabbed the first aid kit, opened it, pulled out a flask of something, and poured its contents down Scorpia's throat. This seemed to stop her convulsing. She then opened her eyes and murmured:

"D-Did C-Catra know this would happen?"

***

All the princesses were screaming – Adora most of all. She had had to transform to cope with the pain. Now she could hear Light Hope's voice in her head telling her to raise her sword. Adora could even feel her arms being forced up. Suddenly, she remembered all the warnings about the Heart of Etheria. It had been argued about so much over the last few days that she had resigned herself to nothing ever happening with it. So, what had happened? Had Scorpia connected to the Black Garnet? Had she somehow escaped from Horde Prime? Or was he making her do this? Adora dared not to think about it – she physically could not think about it. The pain quickly overcame her and it was all she could do to force the sword back into the ground, destroying it as she did so. Adora then passed out from the effort.

***

Hordak pinned Catra face-down on the floor. He then spoke with Horde Prime's voice:

"You're so pathetic! Did you really think you'd beaten me? Prime sees all! Prime knows all! Prime-" Catra cut him off:

“Prime’s an idiot! This ship, and every ship in your navy, is about to blow up!” Hordak/ Horde Prime growled:

“You’re lying. You would never put your own life in danger.” Catra then yelled:

“Is that what Shadow Weaver told you? You were literally in my mind – how did you miss the crippling depression and self-doubt?” With that, she pushed Hordak/ Horde Prime off her and ran for the door. She had decided she wanted to live the rest of her short life without being strangled. Unfortunately, Shadow Weaver suddenly entered the room, blocking her escape as she did so. She was flanked by at least five clones. Catra stopped in her tracks and heard Hordak/ Horde Prime gasp angrily behind her:

“Shadow Weaver? You’re the one preventing my brothers from hearing me?” Shadow Weaver laughed evilly:

“But of course! You didn’t really think I was working for you, did you? You were working for me! And once I had access to the power of your pool, it was simple to take over the very malleable minds of your brothers.” Catra’s face went pale. This was literally her worst nightmare. What was taking the self-destruct sequence so long? The missiles? The portal? She wanted nothing more than for her existence to end right then and there. But she never got what she wanted. Without uttering a word, Catra closed her eyes and did a swan dive off the platform.

***

Octavia was angry. She was really angry. She was also the current leader of what remained of the Horde, and was following Kyle as he ran back to the Black Garnet chamber. Behind her were three guards and a bot. She could not believe that Lonnie could be this stupid. She had not only let in two princesses, but Scorpia and Entrapta? The only two, besides Adora, who knew anything about the layout of the Fright Zone, and could cause serious damage? And that was exactly what they had done! So much so that Scorpia had hurt herself! Or maybe not - Kyle had been rather

vague with the details. Either way, it was not good and, as soon as she had had a chance to take control of the situation, both of them were getting thrown in cells. Lonnie too, unless she had a good explanation for all this.

Once she reached the Black Garnet chamber, Octavia quickly became confused by what she saw. Scorpia was lying on the floor, rubbing her head. Entrapta was hugging her and squealing happily. Rogelio and Lonnie were standing next to them, looking up at the sky. This prompted Octavia to do the same and she gasped at what she saw – beautiful little dots of light littered across the sky. She exclaimed:

"What are those? What happened to the sky?" Entrapta responded:

"They're stars! We just went through a portal! Scorpia helped to activate it!" Scorpia then said, as emphatically as she could:

"Yeah but I promise I had no idea that would happen!" Octavia, too stunned to speak, looked back up at the sky. Lonnie then spoke up:

"For the record, I didn't know this would happen either." Octavia lowered her head again and growled:

"Clearly. Alright, you all have one minute. What. Is. Going. On?"

***

When Adora woke up, Bow and Glimmer were on either side of her. Glimmer immediately leaned down and cried out:

"Adora? ADORA?" Bow then gently sat her up, asking:

"Are you okay? Do you know who we are?" Adora raised an eyebrow and smiled:

"Bow and Glimmer. How could I forget you?" With that, the Best Friend Squad had their first hug in days. It was a wonderfully

sweet moment that was sadly broken up by Swift Wind who, poking Adora with his horn, exclaimed:

"Adora! You're not going to believe this! There are stars outside! Whatever just happened brought back the stars!" Bow then sighed and explained:

"Yeah, the Heart of Etheria. It opened a portal, just like Entrapta said it would. We're in the wider universe." Before he could finish that thought, however, there was suddenly a series of thunderous explosions across, and above, all of Etheria. Frosta, who had been outside, came running into the base, yelling:

"Guys! All of Horde Prime's ships and spires are blowing up!"

***

"You'll pay for this, bitch!" Hordak/ Horde Prime yelled furiously before activating his arm cannon. Shadow Weaver continued laughing evilly:

"You idiot! Don't you see? The Heart of Etheria has been activated and we have finally been brought out of the dimension of Despondos! I not only control every clone on this ship, but every clone in your empire! Every one of your ships across the entire universe is now linked with this one! I control everything!" As the clones behind her began to advance, an alarm began blaring:

"Self-destruct in 30 seconds. 30…29…28…" Everyone paused and Hordak/ Horde Prime roared:

"Wait, she wasn't bluffing? NO!" He then turned and ran for his control panel. Two of the clones then ran forward and grabbed him, pinning him to the ground. Shadow Weaver yelled mockingly:

"If this is Catra's doing, it will come to nothing. She's a coward who never amounted to anything!" Hordak/ Horde Prime desperately fought against his brothers before finally giving up. He smiled sadly:

“Well then, it seems we both miscalculated.” The alarm continued:

“…5…4…3…2…1…0.” Nothing happened. Shadow Weaver began laughing once more:

“Hahaha! See?” Then everything exploded.

Chapter End Notes

How mad would you be if I ended it there? XD
JK of course I won't! I'm way too invested now! So, any ideas for how I save Catra this time?

Catra Remembers Everything

Chapter Notes

> Hey everybody! Here's the final instalment of me desperately saving Catra again. I hope you enjoy it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora and all the princesses stared at the sky in amazement. It was just like Frosta said: all of Horde Prime's ships and spires were blowing up, causing an untold amount of damage as they did so. Glimmer gasped:

"So many people are going to get hurt! We have to go – now!" Without a moment's hesitation, all the princesses and their friends ran off into the Whispering Woods – abandoning the old Horde base and Catra's badge.

As they ran, Adora could not help but look up as yet more explosions filled the sky. A tear rolled down her cheek. She knew Catra had done this, and she knew she probably died doing it. Adora did not know how to handle this information – she could not handle it. All she could do was put all her effort into helping everyone who needed saving - even at the expense of her own safety and sanity. Maybe that way she could still fulfill her destiny. Maybe that way she could forget that she never got to say goodbye.

***

When Catra had let herself fall, she had neither wanted nor expected to be saved. However, a group of clones (now controlled by Shadow Weaver) had caught her using a net, pulling her to safety two floors below the platform. Once they had her, the clones had started hitting, clawing and kicking Catra – ensuring she would not escape again.

Catra howled in pain when one of the clones scratched her down the side of her face, splicing her ear in the process. Others cut her arms and legs, and Catra could feel her ribs being broken with every hit. Catra fought back valiantly, taking out at least three of them, but there were too many. Catra was overpowered and soon she was completely unable to fight back. She collapsed on the ground and let herself pass out from the pain. As she did, one of the clones leaned over her, emitting Shadow Weaver's horrible laugh as he did so. Catra sincerely hoped it would not be the last thing she ever heard.

When Catra woke up, an alarm was blaring. It took a second for her to realize that the ship was about to self-destruct. She then slowly pushed herself up, looking around. The clones had disappeared and part of the ceiling had fallen through. She also realized that there was now very little oxygen, meaning that her wounds were suddenly the least of her problems.

Using all her remaining strength, Catra began to crawl for the door. It had helpfully been left open. After what seemed like an eternity, she made it through to the adjoining corridor. She then recognized where she was, breathing a labored sigh of relief when she identified the teleportation chamber. As she began crawling towards it, more of the ceiling fell through, trapping her leg. Ready to give up and accept her fate, Catra lay flat on the floor, closed her eyes and took what she thought would be her final breath. Catra then heard a voice she would never forget:

"It doesn't matter what they do to us. You look out for me and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other." Catra grunted in agony. Adora – she had to get back to Adora.

Using strength she did not know she had, Catra pulled herself free from the debris, practically rolling into the teleportation chamber. Catra laughed internally – it had been much closer than she had thought. Taking a final deep breath (there really was no more oxygen at this point), Catra dragged herself to the control panel. The clone manning it had fainted on the controls. Catra then

noticed her claw marks by his feet – this was the same teleportation chamber she had taken Scorpia and Entrapta to.

The blood loss finally began to affect Catra, and she struggled to remember where she had sent her friends. She knew it was somewhere on Etheria, and it was extremely unlikely that any new coordinates had been entered since she had been dragged out. Using yet more strength Catra did not know she had, she pulled herself up, shoving the clone's body so it began to fall off the control panel. She then leapt onto the teleportation pad and everything went black.

***

Octavia ran through the Fright Zone with the squad and princesses hot on her tail. All the ships hovering over the Fright Zone had blown up, with the debris falling on top of them. She had to get to the Force Commander's control tower. There was an intercom there – she would give orders for everyone to get to the bomb shelter (if they had not already done so). Now running back the way they had come, the princesses suddenly stopped and screamed at the same time. This caused Octavia and the squad to stop and stare at the one thing scarier than impending doom: Catra.

Octavia's eyes went wide. The former Force Commander was lying in the spot where Lonnie said she found the princesses. She was bloody and bruised, with a torn uniform and a large cut down the side of her face. She was not moving.

Scorpia was the first to react. She ran over to Catra, knelt down and tried to figure out whether she was still breathing. This was remarkably difficult with claws, however. Entrapta then rushed over, immediately putting her ear to Catra's chest. She then looked up and announced:

"She's alive! I can hear her heartbeat!" Before Octavia could say anything, Lonnie asked:

“What happened to her? Did she fight Horde Prime or something?” Octavia then lost it, yelling:

“We don’t have time for this! Just pick her up and bring her with us! We need to get to the control tower!” With that, she resumed her run.

Octavia dared not think of the implications of having the former Force Commander back in the Fright Zone, especially the one effectively responsible for the Horde’s current situation. If she had any sense, she would just leave Catra to die. It would be a mercy compared to what the rest of the Horde wanted to do to her. So why did she decide to save her? Catra had saved Scorpia and Entrapta. They cared about her. And maybe, just maybe, Octavia wanted someone to care about her too. Maybe she wanted to be nice for once.

***

It had been about an hour since Horde Prime’s army was destroyed. The princesses were currently on the Plumerian border, surrounded by scared and injured Etherians. Glimmer had so many questions, but she also had no time to ask them. The damage caused by the explosions had injured dozens of people in the Whispering Woods alone and, now that Adora could no longer transform (no one had quite been able to process that yet), helping them had become so much harder. Glimmer closed her eyes as her mind wandered to the rest of Etheria. Had all the other kingdoms been hit just as badly? Her thoughts were interrupted by Bow calling her name. Glimmer opened her eyes and teleported over to him.

When Glimmer materialized next to him, she found herself staring at the tracker pad he held in his hand. Scorpia was on the screen. She said:

“Hiya Glimmer! Long-time no see!” Glimmer smiled happily:

“Scorpia! I’m so glad you’re okay! We were all so worried! Where are you?” Scorpia suddenly looked sad. She said:

“I’m in the Fright Zone. Entrapta’s here too, along with the rest of the Horde. I-” Glimmer cut her off:

“The Horde? The Horde is back in the Fright Zone?!” A voice off-screen growled:

“Yes!” The owner of the voice then turned Scorpia’s tracker pad to face her. Bow recognized Octavia. The new Force Commander continued with a menacing tone:

“You got a problem with that, princess?” Glimmer growled back at her:

“I’m a queen, and, yes, I might have a problem with that!” Bow then put his hand on Glimmer’s shoulder, saying:

“Hey, it’s okay! I know her! I was a prisoner on her ship once! She’s not all bad!” Glimmer and Octavia both stared at him in disbelief. Glimmer then muttered:

“Bow, think very hard about what you just said.” Ignoring her, Octavia asked:

“Aren’t you that sad kid? The one who asked me about my eye?” Bow gulped and muttered:

“Do people not usually ask about your eye?” Glimmer then groaned in frustration, saying:

“Okay, we are getting way off-topic!” She then turned back to Octavia:

“Can you please hand the tracker pad back to Scorpia?” Octavia rolled her eyes and gave the device back to the princess. Once Scorpia was back on the screen, Bow said:

“Quickly, tell Glimmer what you told me!” Scorpia looked nervously over to where Octavia was standing. She then took a deep breath and said:

“Catra’s here and she’s really badly hurt. Entrapta says she’s dying. You need to come and help her! She-Ra can heal her, right?” Glimmer’s eyes went wide. Catra was still alive? How? And, more importantly, how could they help her without She-Ra? Thinking about She-Ra reminded Glimmer that Adora was standing not too far away, handing out emergency supplies with Perfuma. She would want to know about this. Glimmer sighed sadly and said:

“I’m afraid Adora isn’t She-Ra anymore. But, if you like, I can still bring her over. Catra and Adora are…close, right?” Bow nodded and Scorpia gave a sad smile. Everyone knew how close Catra and Adora were. Bow then said:

“We’ll be right over! Where are you in the Fright Zone?” Scorpia cleared her throat before saying:

“We’re in the med bay. It’s the building behind Horror Hall.” Bow raised his eyebrow.

“You’ve got a place called ‘Horror Hall’? Wow.” Glimmer pinched her nose and groaned:

“Bow, not now.” With that, Bow straightened up and began searching for the location on his device. After finding it, he showed it to Glimmer, saying:

“There it is.” Glimmer nodded and said:

“Got it.” She then turned back to Scorpia, saying:

“We’ll be right over, okay?” Scorpia nodded, saying:

“Thanks you guys! Please hurry!” As soon as the call ended, Glimmer teleported over to where Adora was standing.

“Adora?” Adora looked up and gave a forced smile.

“Hey! Everything okay?” Glimmer opened her mouth to speak, but no sound came out. She knew exactly how Adora would feel once she told her about Catra. It was the same way she felt when Bow had told her about Adora. However, this time there was no antidote – no hope. She-Ra was gone, Catra would die, and Adora would blame herself. Glimmer was heartbroken at the thought. She was then woken from said thoughts by Adora who, putting down the box she was holding, asked:

“Glimmer! What happened? Tell me!” Glimmer teared up, finally saying:

“It’s Catra. She’s in the Fright Zone and…she’s dying. Scorpia just called to tell us.” Adora’s face went white. She lost the ability to speak. After a moment of awful silence, Glimmer tentatively asked:

“Do you want to go and say goodbye?” Adora nodded, her eyes watering as she did so. Glimmer motioned for Bow to come over. Once he did, Glimmer teleported the Best Friend Squad to the heart of the Fright Zone.

***

“It’s okay! They’re coming!” Scorpia’s words did little to comfort Entrapta. She was sitting by Catra’s side, hugging her knees and rocking back and forth nervously. It had been better when Adora was hurt – at least then she could help! She could identify the problem and offer a solution. But she had no idea what had happened to Catra and there was no way of knowing if she could be saved.

As Scorpia sat down next to her, Entrapta wordlessly pulled her closer with her hair. Scorpia smiled and accepted Entrapta’s invitation to hug. As Entrapta began to cry quietly into Scorpia’s shoulder, the former Force Captain said:

“Hey! It’s okay! She’ll be alright – Catra’s strong! She’s been through worse, right guys?” Scorpia had turned to the rest of the room for support but had greatly over-estimated their willingness to offer it.

It had been almost an hour since Octavia had made it to the control tower, where she had successfully ordered everyone to head to Horror Hall (the bomb shelter). Once she, the squad and princesses had made it there, it was all Octavia could do to get Catra through to the med bay. Nearly every member of the Horde tried to block their way.

The Horde saw Catra as the traitor responsible for its defeat – she did not deserve mercy. Octavia was inclined to agree, but she also knew they had all done things they were not proud of. She knew about Catra’s heroism onboard Horde Prime’s ship - she deserved the chance to explain herself. She needed She-Ra to heal her. Despite this resolve, however, Octavia was losing her patience.

Octavia was now standing by the door of the med bay which, surprisingly, had no other patients (not that there was a doctor to see any if there were). She had just managed to calm the other Force Captains, assuring them that she was not going crazy. She had argued that Catra needed to get better so they could find out what had happened with the Second Battle of Brightmoon - not to mention what was currently happening with Horde Prime’s army. If She-Ra, or Queen Glimmer, caused any trouble, she would deal with it.

Meanwhile, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle were sitting on the bed opposite Catra’s, trying their best not to draw attention to themselves. Catra herself was hooked up to a monitor on the bed nearest the door (Lonnie had said it was her usual bed). Her condition had gotten steadily worse, with her breathing becoming erratic. The squad and princesses had done their best to bandage her wounds and wake her up, but she was still unconscious. Entrapta was convinced she had extensive internal injuries, and that Catra was now in a coma.

With no one answering her question, Scorpia tightened her grip around Entrapta, hoping that her hug would be enough to assure her.

***

When Catra woke up again, she was in so much pain she could not think straight. She cleared her airway, slowly opening her eyes to see a neon light shining straight into them. She then heard Adora's voice again:

"Catra? Catra, can you hear me? It's me, I'm here!" And then Catra saw her. Adora's beautiful face, framed by loose golden hair, smiling tearfully down at her. Catra could tell she had just given some great emotional speech, probably telling her how much she loved her - even though she did not deserve it. In true Catra fashion, she decided to mess with her. With great effort, Catra wheezed:

""That…was a…beautiful…speech." Catra then coughed again, causing Adora to jump off the bed in true Adora fashion, ready to save the day. Catra did not feel her hand grab hers, but it did. Adora turned to look at her in confusion. That was when Catra realized where she was – the med bay. She was even in the same bed. Hundreds of emotions hit her at once. Adora then said:

"Catra, you have to let me go! I have to get you help!" Before Catra could respond, she felt a sharp pain in her chest. It hurt so much she thought she would faint again. Adora pulled her hand free and began to run away. No, no she must not do that! Using all the strength she had, Catra called out:

"Wait…please…stay." That made Adora stop. Catra winced upon realizing that was one of the first times that had worked. At the same time, she realized she was dying. Even though the falling body of the clone had successfully activated the teleportation process, even though Adora was actually here with her, it was obvious nothing could be done. Not even She-Ra had saved her. Catra caught her breath and continued:

"You know…no one can…save me…Adora." She wanted to take the pressure off Adora, make her come back and hold her like she used to. But of course Adora did not understand that. She replied:

"No, I can! I just turned into She-Ra! I just need to-" Catra raised her hand, hoping that would get her to stop. It did. Catra could really feel herself falling out of consciousness now, and she had no way of knowing whether this would be the last time she would see Adora. She had to say it – what she had wanted to say for such a long time:

"Adora…I…love…you…" Then the world faded to black. Catra could just make out Adora screaming her name. Honestly, she preferred it to Shadow Weaver's laugh. Catra was happy that that was the last thing she got to hear.

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Adora knew where they were even before the sparkles dissipated. She recognized the feel of the tiled floor beneath her boots, not to mention the smell of anesthetic mixed with metal and ration bars. She was in the med bay. Once her eyes adjusted to the dim lighting, she saw Scorpia and Entrapta by Catra's bed (it had been used so often by her – it was basically her bed). Scorpia was blocking her view of Catra, but she quickly moved out of the way so Adora could see her. When Adora saw Catra's face, it was like time stood still.

Catra's eyes were closed, a large cut running down the right side of her face. Whatever had cut her had also cut her ear, with part of it now gone. Her beautiful mane had been completely removed, leaving her with a short and equally sexy haircut. Adora liked it but knew it was something Catra would never have wanted. Horde Prime must have forced it on her – a punishment for saving Adora.

Adora gulped as she slowly approached the familiar bed. She tried not to cry but could barely keep the tears from falling. She could just make out the irregular rise and fall of Catra's chest as she

struggled to breath. Adora then realized that her arms and legs were covered in bandages. What had happened to her? Before she could ask, Octavia's voice bellowed:

"Okay, no funny business! Turn into She-Ra, heal her and leave! I don't want you princesses in here any longer than necessary!" Glimmer then teleported over to Octavia and a heated conversation ensued. Adora paid no attention, however, continuing to make her way over to Catra. Once she was by her side, Adora finally lost control. A loud sob escaped her chest as the tears finally escaped.

Entrapta, visibly uncomfortable with this display of emotion, silently walked away from the bed, heading for the door. Scorpia wordlessly followed her. Glimmer then ushered Octavia outside, followed closely by Bow. Once they had left, Lonnie cautiously moved over to Adora. She put her hand on her shoulder, saying:

"For what it's worth, she was a way better commander than Shadow Weaver." Adora smiled at that. Rogelio then came over and growled loudly. Lonnie translated:

"Rogelio says she was a good person. He's right - she saved Scorpia and Entrapta. She wanted to stop Horde Prime. She didn't - *doesn't* - deserve this." Adora stifled a sob, unable to find the words to respond. Kyle then got up and ran over to her, giving her a hug and saying:

"It's great to have you back, Adora!" Adora hugged him back. Lonnie then put her hand on his shoulder, pulling him away. She grunted:

"You don't have long, Adora! Work your magic! We'll be outside if you need us!" She then ushered her squad mates out the door, closing it behind them. Catra and Adora were finally alone in the med bay, just like they had been four years ago.

Adora leaned down and stroked Catra's uninjured cheek with her left hand. She then gently ran her right hand along her facial

injury. It had been cleaned and was already beginning to scar. Adora then moved her hand to the bottom of Catra's neck, feeling for her pulse. It was weak but it was there. Catra was alive – all she needed was for She-Ra to save her. But She-Ra did not exist anymore – Adora had sacrificed her to save all of Etheria.

For what felt like the first time in her life, Adora truly regretted making the right choice. She would never admit it but, in that moment, if she could go back in time, she would have chosen not to break the sword. She would destroy whatever she had to destroy, kill whoever she had to kill, just so she could save Catra. She did not care about her destiny anymore. She did not even care about her duty. She wanted Catra. She was all she had ever wanted.

Adora sobbed loudly – she desperately wanted to save Catra. That was when she remembered Lonnie's words – she did not have long. She had wanted a chance to say goodbye - this was it. Adora lay down on the bed beside Catra, just like she used to do. She wrapped her arms around her, careful not to put pressure on her injuries as she did so. She wiped away her tears, cleared her throat and spoke quietly into Catra's ear:

"Hey Catra. It's just me. I don't know if you can hear me…but I hope you can. I just wanted to say…I'm sorry. I'm sorry for whatever I did or didn't do that messed up what we had. I'm sorry I left you. I'm sorry you were so hurt that you chose not to follow me. I'm sorry I let so many terrible things happen to you… I'm sorry." Adora paused before continuing:

"I also want to say that…I love you. I've always loved you. You're perfect, Catra. You're all I ever wanted…the only reason I didn't leave the Fright Zone sooner…the only reason I wanted to stay. Please…stay with me now…" With that, Adora began sobbing once more. She could feel herself being taken over by raw emotion.

The need to save Catra dominated every thought in Adora's mind and the rage she felt at being unable to do that consumed her. Just then, she could have sworn she felt the familiar warmth of

She-Ra. Adora then opened her eyes and saw her hands were glowing. This caused her to jump up and gasp, making the glow go away. Adora frantically yelled:

"No no no no no no! Come back! COME BACK!" It was no use, nothing Adora did seemed to work. That was when she heard Catra cough. Adora instantly leaned over her, praying She-Ra had done more than just wake her up.

"Catra? Catra, can you hear me? It's me, I'm here!" Catra opened her eyes and stared at her. She then forced a smile, weakly muttering:

"That…was a…beautiful…speech." She then coughed again and Adora saw she was coughing up blood. She-Ra had not done much to help after all. Adora quickly jumped off the bed, wanting to go and get help, but Catra's hand caught hers. Adora turned to stare at her in confusion. Catra looked like she was about to pass out. Adora pleaded:

"Catra, you have to let me go! I have to get you help!" Catra responded by closing her eyes, groaning in pain, and tightening her grip on Adora. This caused Adora to pull her hand free and start running for the door. She stopped, however, when she heard Catra's weak voice murmur:

"Wait…please…stay." Adora turned to see Catra forcing another smile at her. She continued to talk slowly, making it clear that every word hurt:

"You know…no one can…save me…Adora." Adora began to tear up again. She protested:

"No, I can! I just turned into She-Ra! I just need to-" Catra raised her hand again, telling Adora to stop talking. She then said:

"Adora…I…love…you…" With that, Catra collapsed, and the monitor she was hooked up to began to beep like crazy. Adora cried:

“Catra! CATRA!” She ran back to her side, climbing back on the bed and cradling Catra in her arms. This would not be the end – this could not be the end! With every ounce of her strength, Adora closed her eyes and focused on her emotions: her undying love for Catra and her desperate need to save her. She cried:

“Please, Catra! Please, just this once, stay!” It was then that she felt the familiar warmth once more and, when she opened her eyes, she was She-Ra again.

The glow of She-Ra’s magic spread over Catra. Adora let it finish the job of healing her, unlike last time. Once the glowing stopped, Adora had barely any time to process her new look before Catra coughed again. This time there was no blood and all her wounds had miraculously disappeared. Catra then opened her eyes and smiled:

“Hey Adora.” Adora gave a giant tearful smile, pulling Catra into a hug as she did so. Catra slowly hugged her back. Adora, still She-Ra, then asked her:

“You love me?” Catra laughed and pulled back from the hug:

“You’re such an idiot.” Adora, who Catra noticed now looked criminally attractive, gave a cheeky smile, saying:

“I know. Have I ever told you I love you too?” That was when Catra knew she had been right to not give up. She had been right to put herself through hell on Horde Prime’s ship. It had all been worth it.

Catra smiled lovingly at Adora, reached both her hands up to Adora’s face and pulled her in for a much needed (and greatly anticipated) kiss. This caused Adora to change back into herself, but she neither noticed nor cared. She pulled Catra closer, deepening the kiss and finally getting the love she deserved.

Catra wrapped her arms around Adora’s neck, pulling wires off them as she did so. She was still half-convinced this was actually heaven, and that she had really died on Horde Prime’s ship. But

Adora was here – she just knew it. She had stayed and she would not leave again. They had both been broken, and it was by grace that that brokenness had brought them back together.

Chapter End Notes

Hey guys! So, I was going to continue, but, after starting the next chapter, it just didn't feel right. I have unintentionally already given you the perfect ending!

If you desperately want answers for what happens next, I encourage you to read Part 2! Otherwise, thank you so much for reading this fic all the way to the end!

Your comments and kudos mean the world to me. I hope you enjoyed it!

P.S. You can also find me on Tumblr (@commanderlioness)! Feel free to come and say hi! :p

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!